

A WORKING REFERENCE

The Manipulation Handbook

*How influence is applied, how it is
spotted, and how it is refused*

Compiled and synthesised from the primary sources listed on the
next page. Original exposition throughout; the sources are credited,
not reproduced.

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Entries: 33 • Sources ingested: 4

Sources, Attribution and Purpose

What this book is

This handbook is an *original synthesis*. It is not a republication, abridgement, paraphrase-in-place, or substitute for any source it draws on. Every idea taken from a source is credited to that source by short ID tag (B1, B2, ...) at entry level and in the dossier appendix, and all prose here was written afresh for this handbook. Chapter and law titles from the sources are used only as short identifying labels.

Primary sources ingested so far

- B1** Sparkman, R. B. *The Art of Manipulation*. Cope Allied Publishing / Dial Press, 1978. Contributed: street-level tactic set (Tactics 1–14), character typologies, the financial-dealings chapter, the “unargue” method, ingratitude handling.
- B2** *The Art of Manipulation* – condensed study summary of B1 (Bookey edition, 2025). Contributed: chapter-level outline of B1 used only to cross-check coverage of B1. Treated as a *secondary* witness: where B1 and B2 disagree, B1 wins. B2 never originates a claim.

B3 Greene, R. *The 48 Laws of Power*. Viking/Penguin, 1998.
Contributed: the 48-law strategic layer, transgression/observance case structure, the “reversal” device, courtiership and timing doctrine.

The authoritative machine-readable list is `registry/books.yaml`. Adding a source is documented in `docs/INGESTION.md`; it is an append-only operation.

Why the material is presented this way

The sources describe techniques that are used on ordinary people every day, in sales, in offices, in families and in politics. A technique you cannot name is a technique you cannot refuse. Each entry therefore carries its **Counters** slot before its **Cost** slot, and the recognition material (**Tells**) is given as much weight as the execution material (**Moves**). The handbook is written to be usable defensively first.

Nothing here is advice to harm, defraud, coerce or exploit anyone. Several entries describe conduct that is illegal in many jurisdictions (fraud, extortion, blackmail, misrepresentation). Those entries exist so the reader can recognise the pattern being used against them; the **Cost** slot records the legal and practical blowback. Use this book on yourself and in your own defence.

Editorial policy on “padding”

The sources spend most of their length on historical anecdote, case narrative, repetition and moral hedging. All of that is stripped. What is kept is the transferable mechanism: what the move is, why it lands, how it shows up, how it is answered, and where it fails. Where a source’s only contribution to an entry is an

anecdote, the anecdote is dropped and the entry is not padded to compensate. See `docs/STYLE-GUIDE.md`.

How to Read an Entry

The handbook is organised by *subject*, not by book. Sources are merged into a single argument, so a reader never has to know which book said what in order to follow the text. Provenance is available on demand, not in the way.

The anatomy of an entry

- **Core** – the whole entry in one to three sentences. If you read nothing else, read this. It is boxed because it must never be buried.
- **Mechanism** – why the move works on a human nervous system. A tactic whose mechanism you understand can be adapted; one you merely memorise breaks on first contact.
- **Tells** – how to spot it being used, usually on you. Bulleted, observable, and deliberately behavioural rather than intuitive.
- **Moves** – how it is executed. Numbered and imperative. This is the slot that makes the entry useful defensively: you cannot recognise a sequence you have never seen described.
- **Counters** – what to do about it. Given equal weight to Moves.
- **Cost** – when the move fails, what it costs the user, and the blowback it produces. Every technique in this book has a failure mode, and an entry without one is incomplete rather than optimistic.

- **Field note** – a short modern illustration written for this handbook. Not from the sources.

Notation

- [B1], [B3] – superscript tags naming the source a claim came from. Full details in Appendix A and `registry/books.yaml`.
- **Drawn from:** – the entry’s complete source list.
- **See also:** – other entry numbers. The book is a lattice, not a line; follow the links when an entry assumes one.
- T-**nn-~~nn~~** – entry number: chapter, then position in chapter.

Order of reading

Parts I and II are prerequisites: they cover what manipulation is, who does it, and how to read a person. Parts III–V are the technique layers, and can be read in any order. Part VI is defence and can be read first by anyone who is currently being worked on. Part VII is the cost accounting.

Contents

*The list below is generated from the entry headers
(`registry/compiled/index.tex`), so it can never disagree with the body
of the book. Entries marked (planned) exist as scaffolding only: the slot
structure is in place and the writing has not been done yet.*

Contents

Part I

The Terrain

What manipulation is, who practises it, and what in the target makes it work. Nothing in the rest of the book can be used or defended against without this part, because every later tactic is a variation on one of four or five facts stated here.

Chapter 1

What Manipulation Actually Is

Definitions, and the difference that matters

Three activities get called manipulation. They differ in the lever they use, in what the target is left holding afterwards, and in how much the practitioner pays for it. The definitions below are used consistently for the rest of the book.

1.1 The Five-Percent Premise

A minority operates; the majority is operated on

CORE

Both sources open on the same claim: the ability to steer other people is not evenly distributed. A small minority exercises it deliberately and the large majority absorbs it. The minority is not smarter. It has simply decided that other people's behaviour is a variable it may act on, while the majority treats that behaviour as weather.

MECHANISM

The asymmetry is maintained by an assumption rather than by a skill. Most people operate on a default rule — that others are broadly like them, broadly honest, and broadly acting in good faith — because that rule is cheap and usually correct enough. The practitioner suspends it. Once suspended, every interaction becomes readable in terms of interest, and reading interest is most of what the rest of this book teaches. The majority does not lose these exchanges because it is dull; it loses them because it is running a cooperative protocol against an opponent who is not. The majority also loses because much of what it does is not decided at all: a single feature of a situation — a title, a queue, a deadline — can fire a rehearsed response, and whoever produces that feature never has to meet the merits.

TELLS

- You find out about an arrangement after it has been decided.
- Your reasons for refusing are answered one at a time, patiently, by someone who clearly knew them in advance.
- You concede things you did not intend to concede, and cannot locate the moment you did it.
- The other party's stated motive changes between tellings, while your own stays fixed.

MOVES

1. Treat the distribution as a fact, not as a grievance.
2. Assume any given counterpart may be in the minority until their behaviour proves otherwise.

3. Convert the default rule from *trust until shown otherwise* to *verify while appearing to trust*.

COUNTERS

- Delay. Almost every technique in this book depends on momentum, and momentum dies overnight.
- Require writing. A person working you verbally will often decline to repeat it in a form you can keep.
- Ask the interest question out loud: *what do you get if I say yes?* The answer, not the tone, is the information.
- Keep a record of your own concessions. Counting them removes the illusion that you chose each one freely.

COST

The premise is a posture, and postures have a cost. Held too tightly it produces a person who cannot accept help, cannot be surprised by generosity, and reads every kindness as a setup — which is itself a form of being controlled, just by fear. Both sources acknowledge the trade. The usable version is situational: verify hard where money, commitment or reputation is at stake, and let the default rule stand where it does not.

Drawn from: B1, B3, B4

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-01-02, T-04-01, T-06-04

1.2 Three Different Activities

Persuasion, manipulation and coercion are not the same move

CORE

Persuasion changes what a person wants. Manipulation changes what a person believes about the situation, so that what they want changes on its own. Coercion leaves what they want intact and makes it expensive. Confusing the three produces bad defences, because each is answered differently.

MECHANISM

The distinction lies in what is being worked on and what the target is left holding. A persuaded person can restate your argument and still disagree; nothing was hidden. A manipulated person acts on a picture of the situation that you edited — the alternatives, the urgency, the cost, who benefits — and acts on it willingly, which is why they do not resist and why they often defend the decision afterwards. A coerced person complies while disagreeing, and retains the grievance. That is the practical difference: manipulation buys consent, coercion buys compliance, and consent is far more durable than compliance because it does not need to be re-applied. The line between the first two is crossed without an argument whenever the edited picture is installed by a single manufactured feature rather than by a claim the target could have examined.

TELLS

- Persuasion: the argument is on the table and you can repeat it back.
- Manipulation: the options, the timing or the stakes have been arranged, and you feel you chose freely.
- Coercion: the cost of refusing is stated or obvious, and the offer does not improve when you hesitate.

MOVES

1. Name which of the three is in use before responding to it.
2. Against persuasion, answer the argument.
3. Against manipulation, reconstruct the situation independently: get the real options, the real deadline, the real price, from a source the other party does not control.
4. Against coercion, stop arguing about the merits and work on the cost of compliance — reduce your exposure, or make the cost of enforcing it higher.

COUNTERS

- Reconstruct the choice set from outside. Manipulation depends on you accepting the frame; a second source breaks it.
- Slow the clock. Manufactured urgency is the most common signal that the picture has been edited.
- Ask for the terms in a form you can keep. Consent built on an edited picture rarely survives being written down.
- For coercion, do not negotiate the framing at all — negotiate the exit.

COST

The boundaries blur in practice, and both sources treat them as blurring. Selective honesty used to disarm someone is manipulation that looks like persuasion; a deadline can be real and manufactured at once. A taxonomy that is too clean makes you confident and wrong. Its use is diagnostic — it tells you which question to ask next — not verdictal.

Drawn from: B1, B3, B4

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-01-01, T-14-01, T-19-01

1.3 Power as an Amoral Instrument

The mechanics do not care what you intend

CORE

The strategic layer of this book treats power as a set of mechanics that operate whether or not you approve of them, and whether or not you intend to use them. Refusing to learn them does not remove them from the environment; it only removes them from your side.

MECHANISM

The argument is descriptive rather than exhortatory. Court dynamics — who is rising, who is exposed, who depends on whom — exist in any hierarchy, and they continue to operate on a person who declines to notice them. What the practitioner adds is attention and choice: seeing the mechanism, and deciding deliberately whether to run it, run against it, or step out of its reach. The moral question is therefore not whether the mechanism exists but what you do once you can see it, which is a question this entry does not answer and the rest of the book keeps returning to.

TELLS

- You are surprised by an outcome that several other people saw coming.
- You describe an arrangement as unfair and nobody in it disagrees, and nothing changes.
- You believe that declining to play is a neutral position rather than a move with a payoff of its own.

MOVES

1. Describe the situation in terms of interest and dependence rather than in terms of fairness.
2. Identify who benefits from the current arrangement and what it costs them to change it.
3. Only then decide whether to work within it, against it, or leave it.

COUNTERS

- Recognising the mechanism is itself the main defence: an arrangement you can describe in terms of interest is one you can decline, price, or exit.
- Refuse the inference that because something is amoral you must be. Seeing the game clearly and playing it badly on purpose are both available options.
- Keep at least one relationship or resource outside the system you are analysing, so that leaving is real rather than rhetorical.

COST

This framing has a known failure mode: it makes every interaction look strategic, which is both untrue and corrosive. Most exchanges are cooperative and most people are not running anything. Held as a permanent lens rather than a diagnostic tool, it produces isolation and misreading, and the book's own later material on isolation and on the cost of using people is a correction of it. It is also a description of how power behaves, not a licence; several of the moves described elsewhere in this handbook are crimes in most jurisdictions.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-01-01, T-01-04, T-27-01

1.4 Intent Is the Only Ethical Switch

The same move is a defence or an attack depending on purpose

CORE

Nothing in the technique set distinguishes a defender from an operator. The same read, the same delay, the same controlled disclosure serves both. What separates them is the purpose the move is put to, and the only place that purpose is visible is in what the target is left holding afterwards.

MECHANISM

A technique is a way of arranging a situation. Arrangement is neutral in the same sense that a lock is neutral: it keeps people out or keeps them in depending on which side you stand on. Learning the arrangement does not commit you to a side, but it does commit you to knowing which side you are on, because the moves feel identical from the inside. The practical test is external — whether the other person ends up better informed or worse, whether they could reconstruct what happened if they tried, and whether you would be comfortable with them knowing exactly what you did and why.

TELLS

- You are editing what someone knows in order to get a decision you have already made.
- You would not want the method described to the person you are using it on.

- The other party ends the exchange less able to see their own position than they were at the start.

MOVES

1. Decide the outcome you want before choosing a method, and check whether the method serves the outcome or merely the moment.
2. Prefer methods that leave the other party's picture of the situation more accurate, not less.
3. Where you must arrange a situation, arrange it toward a result you would defend aloud.

COUNTERS

- Use the disclosure test: if the full method were described to the other person in advance, would the exchange still work? If not, it is manipulation rather than negotiation.
- Use the residue test: afterwards, is the other person better or worse able to look after their own interests?
- If you are the target, the equivalent question is whether you are being left holding a decision you cannot reconstruct.

COST

Intent is not observable, including to yourself in the moment. People running a self-serving move generally experience it as reasonable, and the rationalisation arrives before the act rather than after. This entry is therefore a discipline rather than a guarantee — useful because it forces the question before the move, weak because the answer it produces is often flattering. The

external tests above are stronger than introspection for exactly that reason.

Drawn from: B1, B2

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-01-02, T-01-03, T-27-01

1.5 Results Are the Only Test

The practitioner's epistemology, and where it fails

CORE

Both sources judge a tactic by whether it worked, not by whether it is elegant, principled or well-argued. That standard is what makes the material usable and what makes it unreliable, and it needs to be held consciously rather than absorbed.

MECHANISM

A results standard selects hard for techniques that exploit stable features of human behaviour — loss aversion, need for consistency, status sensitivity, conflict avoidance — because those pay out repeatedly across situations. It also selects against techniques that are merely correct. The weakness is structural: a single success is not evidence, and the practitioner who learns from outcomes is learning from a small, self-selected, survivorship-biased sample. The con artist's craft is genuinely well calibrated on the marks he meets often and badly calibrated on everything else. The discipline is worth adopting with the sample-size problem attached.

TELLS

- A method is defended by a story rather than by a mechanism.

- Failures are attributed to the situation; successes are attributed to the method.
- No one can say what would count as evidence that the method had stopped working.

MOVES

1. Ask of any tactic: what is the mechanism, and would I expect it to work on a person who does not share this mark's disposition?
2. Keep the failures. They are the only informative data in the set.
3. Prefer tactics whose mechanism you can state, so that you can predict where they break.

COUNTERS

- When someone justifies a method by their success with it, ask what happened the times it did not work.
- Refuse the survivorship sample: the people who were taken in are not in the room to describe it.
- Judge a technique by its mechanism, not by its testimonial.

COST

Applied to yourself, a pure results standard will eventually license something indefensible that happened to work once. Applied to others' claims, it is excellent. The asymmetry is the point: demand mechanism from yourself and accept outcomes from nobody, including the sources of this book. Both are confident in ways their evidence does not support.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-01-03, T-04-01

Chapter 2

The Practitioner's Equipment

What the person doing this is actually good at

Four capacities, none of them charm. Every tactic in Parts III to V degrades quickly without them, which is why most people who try this fail at it.

2.1 Affect Control

Calm is a position, not a temperament

CORE

Whoever is more composed holds the exchange. Anger and excitement are strategically useless to the person feeling them and highly useful to the person provoking them, so the first piece of equipment is the ability to stay flat while the counterpart is not.

MECHANISM

Strong affect narrows attention and shortens the horizon. An angry person optimises for the next thirty seconds and pays for it later; a calm person can hold the sequence in view. That asymmetry is exploitable in both directions, which is why the same source treats keeping yourself composed and making the opponent emotional as one technique rather than two. Composure also conceals information: a flat face gives away nothing about what you want, what you fear, or what you will accept.

TELLS

- Your voice or tempo changes when the subject turns to you.
- You rehearse a reply while the other person is still talking.
- You find yourself trying to win the exchange rather than to get the thing.
- Someone has located a subject that reliably rattles you, and keeps returning to it.

MOVES

1. Identify in advance the two or three subjects that reliably upset you.
2. Treat a rise in your own affect as a signal to stop advancing and start listening.
3. Answer slowly and below the emotional register of the question.
4. If the counterpart is escalating, let them; do not meet the register.

5. Decide the outcome you want before the conversation, and judge each of your own moves against it rather than against the insult.

COUNTERS

- Recognise provocation as information: someone is trying to move you off your plan, which tells you the plan is working.
- Buy time. Delay is the cheapest affect control there is and almost nothing in this book survives it.
- Refuse to be the one who escalates in front of an audience; the audience will attribute the escalation to whoever is louder, not whoever started it.
- If you cannot stay flat, leave. A withdrawn exchange can be resumed; a lost one cannot.

COST

Flatness reads as coldness, and coldness costs trust in the relationships where trust is the currency. Applied everywhere it produces a person nobody confides in and therefore nobody tells anything to — which destroys the information-gathering half of this book. It is a tool for contested exchanges, not a way of living, and it is also the single hardest item in this chapter to acquire, because it requires the self-knowledge listed in T-04-04 first.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-02-02, T-04-03, T-17-01, T-21-03

2.2 Indifference to Being Liked

The willingness to be disliked is the precondition

CORE

Most people lose exchanges because being liked is worth more to them than the thing being negotiated. The practitioner has decided otherwise, at least for the duration of the exchange, and that single difference accounts for a large part of the gap described in T-01-01.

MECHANISM

Being liked is a real asset and treating it as one is correct; the error is treating it as an asset that must never be spent. A person unwilling to spend it telegraphs that in advance, and the counterpart prices it in. Two consequences follow. First, the unwilling person cannot refuse, cannot delay, and cannot let an accusation stand unrefuted — which removes most of the defences in Part VI. Second, they over-explain, and over-explaining is itself a tell. The corollary is that retaliation is almost always a bad trade: winning an argument buys a moment and creates an enemy with a long memory.

TELLS

- You explain yourself more than the situation requires.
- You have conceded something in order to end an uncomfortable silence.
- You are managing how you are perceived by someone whose opinion has no bearing on anything you want.
- You let a false statement about you stand because correcting it would be awkward.

MOVES

1. Before a difficult exchange, decide in advance what you are willing to be disliked for.
2. Answer the question asked and stop. Do not fill the silence that follows.
3. Let small misreadings of you stand uncorrected; spend the correction only where it changes an outcome.
4. Refuse retaliation as a category: it converts a settled matter into an ongoing one.

COUNTERS

- Notice when warmth is being purchased rather than given. A counterpart who works hard to be liked is usually about to ask for something.
- Do not reward over-explanation with more pressure; it trains the other person to keep conceding.
- If you are the one who cannot bear to be disliked, put the decision in writing or hand it to someone else — a rule, a policy, a third party — so that the refusal is not personally yours to make.

COST

Carried too far this produces the person nobody will help, and both sources are explicit that being needed and being trusted are assets worth holding. The usable version is selective: indifference to being liked by the counterpart in a contested exchange, not by everyone. The source that argues for meekness argues for it on effectiveness grounds — retaliation escalates and costs more than it recovers — not on grounds of contempt for the other person.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-02-01, T-06-01, T-16-03, T-26-02

2.3 Patience as Position

Hurry is a tell; waiting is a lever

CORE

Apparent haste signals that you need the outcome more than the other person does, and that signal re-prices the whole exchange against you. Patience is therefore not a virtue here but a position: it keeps your need invisible and keeps the counterpart's need on the table.

MECHANISM

Two mechanisms run together. Perceptually, hurry communicates dependence, and dependence is what the whole of Part III is about concealing. Practically, most situations have a moment at which they become cheap to move — before it, effort is wasted; after it, the opportunity has closed. Detecting that moment requires having watched for longer than the other party expected you to. Impatience collapses both: it reveals the need and it spends the effort at the wrong time.

TELLS

- You have raised your own offer before being asked to.
- You are checking on something far more often than its importance warrants.
- You feel that a delay is a loss rather than a neutral event.
- The other party has begun setting the pace of the exchange.

MOVES

1. Set a horizon before you start, and treat everything inside it as available time rather than lost time.
2. Match the counterpart's response interval instead of beating it.
3. Use the waiting period to gather information, which is the only productive use of it.
4. Act decisively at the moment the situation turns, and not before — standing back while the time is unripe and moving hard when it is ripe are the same skill.

COUNTERS

- Impose a deadline and see whether it holds. Manufactured urgency collapses under a request to wait; real urgency does not.
- Refuse to let pace be set by the other party's calendar. Ask for the reason behind the date.
- If you are being worn down by delay rather than by argument, name it: a tactic that depends on your fatigue stops working when it is identified.

COST

Patience requires that you can afford to wait, and both sources note that the person with high fixed costs cannot. Waiting is a lever only for the party with the smaller exposure, which means the honest first move is often to reduce your exposure before entering the exchange rather than to sit tight inside it. Patience also decays into drift if there is no defined trigger for acting.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-02-01, T-11-01, T-17-02

2.4 Effortlessness

Conceal the work or the work becomes the story

CORE

An accomplishment that looks effortless raises your standing; the same accomplishment with the effort visible invites inspection, envy and imitation. What is concealed is not the result but the labour and the artifice behind it.

MECHANISM

Visible effort invites two unwanted responses. It makes the result look attainable, which lowers the standing it buys you, and it exposes the method, which is the reusable part — a method others can see is a method others can copy or counter.

Effortlessness also disarms scrutiny: people audit what looks strained and accept what looks natural. The discipline is therefore presentational and informational at once.

TELLS

- You have described how hard something was, unprompted.
- You have explained a method to someone who has no need of it.
- Your preparation is visible in the delivery — notes, hedging, over-structuring.

- You feel the need to be credited for the labour rather than the outcome.

MOVES

1. Show the result, not the process.
2. Rehearse until the delivery has no seams, then present it as though it were ordinary.
3. Keep your methods to yourself, including from allies who have no use for them.
4. When asked how you did it, answer at one level of abstraction above the truth.

COUNTERS

- Ask for the method, not the result. A person who cannot or will not describe how something was produced is protecting something.
- Reproduce the work yourself at small scale. Effortlessness does not survive an attempt.
- Watch what someone does not claim credit for; the gap between visible and invisible effort is where the artifice lives.

COST

It makes you un-teachable, which is expensive: a person who conceals method cannot delegate well, cannot build a team, and cannot be replaced — which sounds like an advantage until the workload arrives. It also isolates, since the persona has to be maintained with everyone. And it fails outright where the

audience is expert; effortlessness in front of people who know the craft reads as concealment and buys resentment instead of standing.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-09-01, T-13-04, T-17-03

2.5 Persistence Over Attitude

Choose the animal that produces, not the one that looks impressive

CORE

A confident mood is not equipment; it fails exactly when equipment is needed. What survives failure is the decision to keep going, made in advance and executed without reference to how you feel about it.

MECHANISM

Attitude is a state and states are contingent on circumstances, so an attitude that depends on things going well cannot be relied on when they do not. Persistence is a decision, and decisions can be held against feelings. The distinction matters because the two look identical from outside during good periods, which is why people invest in the wrong one. There is also a scale error: morale that works on a group — a team, a company — does not transfer to an individual operating alone, and most of what is sold as attitude is group morale repackaged.

TELLS

- Your confidence tracks your recent results rather than your plan.

- You cannot say what you would do after the third failure, only that you would stay positive.
- You are borrowing morale from a group you are not currently part of.
- You evaluate options by how impressive they look rather than by what they produce.

MOVES

1. Decide the continuation rule before you start: what you will do after the first, second and third failure.
2. Judge instruments and people by output, not by presentation.
3. Treat a bad period as the expected case rather than as evidence that the plan is wrong.
4. Keep going at reduced scope rather than stopping at full scope.

COUNTERS

- When someone sells you confidence, ask what they do when it runs out. A person with a continuation rule has one; a person with an attitude does not.
- Discount impressive presentation in your own assessment of people and options — the showy animal and the productive animal are priced by different criteria.
- Do not let a group's morale stand in for your own plan.

COST

Persistence with no review is just stubbornness, and the source that recommends it also recommends knowing when to walk away, which is the opposite judgment. The rule needs a stopping condition attached to it or it converts sunk cost into virtue. It is also weak equipment for the exchanges in Part IV, where reading and adapting to the counterpart matters more than continuing; persistence is for campaigns, not conversations.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-02-03, T-08-02

Chapter 3

Character Types

Who works you, and who gets worked

Two typologies, one for the operator and one for the mark. Both sources are strong here and they agree more than they differ: the same handful of dispositions produce both the successful user and the reliable victim.

3.1 The Five Dangerous Marks

Typology of the counterpart you should not engage

CORE

Five dispositions make a counterpart expensive to work against, and they are recognisable early. The instruction is not to handle them better but to decline the engagement: whatever you hope to get from them is unlikely to be worth what they will cost.

MECHANISM

Each type defeats a different assumption. The ordinary model of a counterpart — someone who responds to incentives, forgets small

injuries, and reacts in proportion — fails in a specific way for each. Pride reacts out of all proportion and immediately. Fragile self-esteem reacts slowly and indefinitely. Suspicion misreads everything, including your honesty, and is therefore easy to fool and dangerous to be suspected by. Cold calculation waits and remembers. Literal inability to follow a scheme wastes your resources rather than defeating them. Since the failure modes are structural rather than situational, they cannot be managed by better technique.

TELLS

- *Pride*: reacts violently to a slight that was minor or unintended, and the reaction cannot be reasoned with.
- *Fragile self-esteem*: no open reaction, then a long series of small obstructions you only notice in aggregate.
- *Suspicion*: assumes the worst of everyone, reads motives into accidents, and is easily led to distrust a third party.
- *Long memory*: shows nothing at the time, is cold and unaffectionate, and settles accounts later from a position of advantage.
- *Literal*: does not take a hint, does not follow an implication, and reacts to a joke or a story with flat literalness.

MOVES

1. Test early and cheaply, before committing anything — a story, a joke, a small favour, a small slight.
2. Read the reaction against the five patterns above rather than against what you expected.

3. If a pattern matches, withdraw while the cost of withdrawing is still small.
4. If you have already injured one of them, either settle it completely or remove yourself from their reach. Partial settlement is worse than none.

COUNTERS

- Assume you may be the mark in someone else's typology, and ask which pattern you fit.
- Notice disproportionate reactions in yourself. They are the same tells.
- Where you cannot decline the engagement — a relative, a manager — reduce the surface area: fewer commitments, fewer confidences, nothing in writing that can be held.
- Do not attempt to deceive the literal type; the cost is wasted time, and the return is nothing.

COST

The typology is a heuristic built on extremes, and applied loosely it becomes a way of writing off anyone who has ever been difficult. Most people are none of these types most of the time; the categories describe a settled disposition, not a bad day. It also carries a survivorship problem — the types are named by the people who beat them, so the quiet counterpart who simply declined to engage never appears in the list at all.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-03-02, T-08-01, T-08-02

3.2 The Operator Profile

What the person working you usually looks like

CORE

The experienced operator does not present as dangerous. They present as warm, unlucky, generous with gratitude and slightly in need — a combination that disarms exactly the faculties required to notice them.

MECHANISM

Each feature of the profile does specific work. Warmth and early intimacy accelerate the relationship past the point where ordinary suspicion operates, and they create an obligation to reciprocate. A story of former wealth explains present need without implying incompetence, which makes the request for money legible and sympathetic. Demonstrative gratitude pre-pays the emotional reward so that the target feels the exchange is already balanced. Insistence on their own trustworthiness substitutes a claim for evidence. The profile works because every element is something a decent person also displays; the difference is the concentration and the timing.

TELLS

- Intimacy arrives faster than the relationship can support.
- They were once wealthy, or once important, and something was done to them.
- Gratitude is expressed at length and in advance, before anything has been given.
- Trustworthiness is asserted repeatedly and unprompted.
- The benefit you stand to gain is restated several times by the person proposing the arrangement.

- Every story has them as the person who was wronged.

MOVES

1. Watch for the profile rather than for a single tell — no individual feature is proof, and the pattern is.
2. Note where each feature appears in the sequence: warmth first, story second, gratitude third, request fourth.
3. Treat any request involving money as the point at which the profile is confirmed or dismissed.
4. Do not test them with a confrontation. Test them with a delay: the operator's response to being asked to wait is more informative than their response to being accused.

COUNTERS

- Slow the relationship to its natural rate. Intimacy that is refused acceleration usually reveals itself.
- Require the claim of trustworthiness to be evidenced rather than stated — references, a written agreement, a verifiable history.
- Separate gratitude from obligation. Thanks is not a payment and creates no debt.
- Keep money and personal warmth in different accounts, and notice anyone who tries to move between them quickly.

COST

The profile describes the small-scale operator: the borrower, the deal-maker, the plausible stranger. It is much less useful against

institutional or long-relationship manipulation, where the operator has years of genuine reliability behind them and none of the surface markers. Used indiscriminately it also produces a person who cannot accept kindness, which is a real cost — warmth, misfortune and gratitude are all common in honest people, and the base rate of the profile is low.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-03-01, T-06-01, T-25-01

Chapter 4

Load-Bearing Points

Where a person can be moved from

Every technique in this book is ultimately a way of finding and loading one point in a person: an insecurity, a need, a guilt, a vanity. This chapter is the audit, offensive and defensive.

4.1 The Thumbscrew

Everyone has one load-bearing insecurity

CORE

Every person has a single point — usually an insecurity, an unmanaged emotion, a need, or a small private pleasure — where ordinary resistance does not apply. Finding it is the whole of the preparatory work; once found, it can be loaded repeatedly and cheaply.

MECHANISM

Resistance is distributed unevenly. Most of a person's defences are spread across the areas they have thought about, and

concentrated where they have been hurt before. The unguarded point is unguarded precisely because it is not experienced as a weakness; it is experienced as a preference, a taste, a reasonable sensitivity. That is why it is invisible to its owner and obvious to an observer with no stake. Once identified it does not need to be attacked — it only needs to be referred to. A person defending a point they do not know they are defending will concede almost anything elsewhere to keep it unexamined.

TELLS

- One subject changes their register; everything else stays level.
- They mention the same person, achievement, or grievance far more often than its importance warrants.
- A small remark lands out of all proportion, or is deflected with unusual speed.
- They volunteer information about it unprompted, then steer away.
- Praise in one specific direction reliably produces compliance in another.

MOVES

1. Collect over time rather than probe. The point reveals itself in repetition, not in a single conversation.
2. Test lightly — one remark, then observe rather than follow up.
3. Note what they defend when nothing is under attack.

4. Once identified, refer to it rather than pressing it; the reference does the work.

COUNTERS

- Audit yourself first. Ask which subject changes your register, and what you mention too often. That list is your own exposure.
- Flatten your reactions deliberately in the areas you know are sensitive, especially with someone new.
- Notice disproportionate attention to one part of your life from someone with no standing to give it. Interest that specific, that early, is reconnaissance.
- Give the point air. An insecurity that has been named aloud to a trusted person loses most of its leverage, because it can no longer be threatened silently.

COST

Finding the point takes time and repeated contact, so the technique is weak in one-off exchanges, which is most exchanges. It is also highly fallible: repetition and disproportion have ordinary causes — grief, boredom, a genuine enthusiasm — and misreading them produces confident errors. Used offensively it is the most damaging item in this chapter and the one most likely to produce the long-memory counterpart described in T-03-01.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-03-01, T-04-03, T-04-04, T-22-01

4.2 The Favour Debt

Gratitude is the cheapest lever and the least reliable payment

CORE

A favour creates an account, and both sides know it. The person who gave can draw on it later; the person who received carries an obligation that has no stated amount and no stated due date, which makes it unusually easy to over-draw.

MECHANISM

The obligation works because refusing to repay feels like a statement about your character rather than about the transaction. That is what makes it leverage: the cost of refusing is paid in self-image, not in money. It is also why the lever is unreliable — the account has no agreed balance, so the debtor can always conclude that the debt has been settled, or was never incurred, or was discharged by the resentment the giving produced. What makes it strong in the moment is that the enforcement is public: the person who takes a benefit and returns nothing is marked, and the marking is visible, so the cost of refusing is paid in front of an audience rather than in private. What makes it weak afterwards is the same undefined balance — and an unsettled account is unpleasant enough to hold that relieving it becomes a motive in its own right. Both sources therefore treat gratitude as a poor instrument in either direction: weak to collect on, and expensive to owe.

TELLS

- A gift or favour arrives before anything has been asked, and is larger than the relationship warrants.
- The giver mentions what they did for you, in front of others.

- You find yourself unable to say no to a small request because of a large kindness.
- Resentment appears where gratitude was expected — the debtor's way of cancelling the account.

MOVES

1. Ask in terms of the other party's interest, not in terms of what you have done for them; reminding someone of a past favour gives them a reason to ignore you.
2. Keep accounts small and settled quickly, so that no balance accumulates.
3. Where you must create an obligation, make the repayment specific and immediate, which is worth more later than a vague large debt.
4. If you have done someone a favour you intend to draw on, do not mention it. Mention converts an asset into a grievance.

COUNTERS

- Price the favour at the moment it arrives. A specific, prompt repayment closes the account and removes the leverage entirely.
- Decline unsolicited largeness. An unrequested gift is the classic opening move because it cannot be refused without rudeness — which is exactly why refusing it politely and early is worth the awkwardness.
- Separate the two questions: *was I helped?* and *does this request follow from it?* Most attempts to draw on the account collapse when the second is asked on its own.

-
- Watch your own resentment. It is evidence that you believe you owe something you did not agree to owe.

COST

The debt is real in relationships that are meant to be ongoing — family, long colleagues — and treating every kindness as an opening move eventually leaves you with no one willing to do you one. Both sources accept that generosity functions as an instrument while also noting that it is one of the few instruments whose value depends on not being visibly used. The practical rule is asymmetric: be alert to accounts being opened, be relaxed about ones being closed.

Drawn from: B1, B3, B4

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-04-01, T-18-01, T-25-02

4.3 Vanity as a Handle

Status sensitivity is the most widely distributed weakness

CORE

Almost everyone has a rank in mind for themselves, and almost everyone suspects it is not the rank others assign them. That gap is the most commonly available handle there is, and it can be worked by flattering it, by threatening it, or by appearing to occupy it.

MECHANISM

Status is the one good that cannot be self-supplied, because it consists entirely of other people's assessments. That makes the person permanently dependent on external confirmation, and therefore permanently responsive to whoever appears to be able to

give or withhold it. Flattery works on the gap between self-rank and perceived rank. Provocation works by threatening the same gap. Superiority works by occupying a rank the other person wanted. The reason the handle is so reliable is that defending status feels like defending self, and people will trade material interests to do it.

TELLS

- They correct a minor point that does not affect the outcome.
- Titles, precedents and who-decides matter more to them than what is decided.
- Praise from the right person changes their position within a conversation.
- They will not be seen to lose, even where losing costs nothing.
- Your success in a shared domain produces a change in temperature rather than in words.

MOVES

1. Establish what rank the person believes they hold, and who they believe confers it.
2. Address them at that rank — slightly above it in public, exactly at it in private.
3. Where you are junior, make your competence appear to reflect on them rather than to compete with them.
4. Where you must oppose them, oppose the proposal and never the standing.

-
5. Do not display an advantage you do not need to display.

COUNTERS

- Notice when a proposal is being resisted on grounds of who suggested it. That is status, not substance, and it can be answered by re-attributing the idea.
- Do not pay for praise with concessions. The two feel related and are not.
- Ask yourself which of your positions you would drop if nobody knew you held it. Those are the ones being held for rank.
- Where a superior is insecure, reduce visible competition rather than increasing visible competence — the second reads as the first.

COST

Working the handle is easy and expensive. Status threats produce the longest-lived resentments in this book, and the reaction is disproportionate to the trigger in exactly the way described in T-03-01, so the operator frequently finds they have created an enemy over something they did not intend to do. Flattery also has a ceiling: once recognised it converts to contempt and destroys the relationship's remaining value.

Drawn from: B3, B1

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-03-01, T-04-01, T-09-01, T-18-03

4.4 The Self-Audit

Find your own load-bearing points before someone else does

CORE

The defensive half of this chapter is a short list of your own weak points, written down while you are calm. It is the highest-yield item in Part I, because every technique aimed at you must pass through one of them.

MECHANISM

Techniques do not work on people generically; they work on dispositions specifically. A person who knows that they cannot bear to be thought unfair will notice immediately when a counterpart is building a case around fairness, and that notice converts an automatic reaction into a choice. The audit does not remove the weakness — it cannot — it moves it from the automatic system to the deliberative one, which is where the counters in Part VI operate.

TELLS

- You can name the accusation that would most upset you.
- You know which request you find hardest to refuse.
- You can identify the two or three people whose opinion of you actually changes your behaviour.
- You know what you are unwilling to have examined in public.

MOVES

1. List the subjects that change your register. Use the last three months of real conversations, not a theory about yourself.

-
2. For each, write the request that would be hardest to refuse and the accusation that would be hardest to answer.
 3. Write the pre-commitment: what you will do the next time one of these is loaded. Usually it is delay.
 4. Give the two or three most serious items air with one person who has no use for them.
 5. Review the list when circumstances change — a new job, a new relationship, a loss — because the points move.

COUNTERS

- If you are the target, the audit is the counter. Most of Part VI assumes you have done it.
- Keep a standing delay rule for any request that touches a listed point. The rule does the refusing so you do not have to.
- Ask a person who has known you a long time and gains nothing to name your most obvious one. External observers see these faster than their owners do.
- Treat sudden intense interest in one of your listed points as a boundary condition: slow down, get it in writing, involve a third party.

COST

Self-knowledge is unreliable in exactly the areas the audit targets, which is why the list tends to be incomplete and why the third-party check above is not optional. There is also a failure mode in over-auditing: a person who monitors every reaction becomes unable to act, and hesitation is more exploitable than any

single weakness. The list should be short — five items, not fifty — and read before difficult exchanges rather than during them.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-04-01, T-23-01, T-24-01

Part II

Reading

Intelligence before action. A tactic applied to the wrong person, at the wrong moment, for the wrong stated reason, fails and leaves a mark. This part is about establishing which of those three you are actually dealing with.

Chapter 5

Motives Before Words

The stated reason is never the reason

A request is the visible part of an interest. Working on the request is wasted effort; working on the interest is the whole discipline. This chapter is about getting from one to the other.

5.1 The Real Objection

The stated reason is a position, not a fact

CORE

People give reasons that are presentable. The obstacle actually blocking them is usually something else — money, fear, a third party's opinion, an earlier commitment — and until it is identified, every attempt to move them is aimed at something that is not in the way.

MECHANISM

The stated reason is chosen partly to be defensible and partly because it is the reason the person can articulate. Real obstacles

are frequently unarticulable: an insecurity, an obligation to someone who is not in the room, a private estimate of their own capacity. Answering the stated reason therefore produces a strange pattern — each objection, once fully answered, is replaced by a new one — and that pattern is itself the diagnostic. A person whose real objection has been met stops generating objections; a person whose stated objection has been met produces another.

TELLS

- Objections arrive serially: each resolved one is followed by a fresh one.
- The stated reason would not, if true, prevent the action.
- The reason changes depending on who is present.
- They defend the reason more vigorously than they want the outcome.
- Relief rather than engagement when you stop pressing.

MOVES

1. Stop answering objections and start collecting them. Three in a row is a pattern; one is noise.
2. Ask what would have to be true for them to want this. The answer is usually nearer the real obstacle than anything they have said so far.
3. Offer a face-saving route to the truth: make it respectable for the real reason to be money, fear or someone else's opinion.
4. Address the real obstacle directly once identified, and let the stated reasons fall away on their own.

5. If the real obstacle cannot be addressed, stop. Persuading past it produces compliance that collapses later.

COUNTERS

- Notice your own serial objections. If you have given three reasons for refusing something, the fourth is being manufactured to cover the first.
- Answer the real one, not the presented one, even when doing so is uncomfortable.
- Where someone is mining your objection, give the true reason once and hold it. A single stable refusal is harder to work on than a shifting one.
- Ask for the decision to be deferred. Obstacle-mining depends on the conversation continuing.

COST

Searching for a hidden objection can become a refusal to accept no. A stated reason is sometimes the reason, and the serial-objection test is the only thing separating legitimate persistence from pressure — once the answer is a settled refusal rather than a sequence of pretexts, continuing is the coercion described in T-19-01 and not persuasion. The diagnostic also fails on the literal counterpart from T-03-01, who has no hidden layer to find.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-05-02, T-07-02, T-16-01, T-24-02

5.2 Follow the Interest

Watch where the benefit goes

CORE

Ignore what people say they want and trace what they gain. In any arrangement the flow of benefit is visible long before the motive is stated, and it predicts behaviour with a reliability that no explanation matches.

MECHANISM

Interests are structural: they follow from a person's position, their costs and their income, and they change slowly. Explanations are situational: they are produced for the audience, they change quickly, and they are chosen for effect. Tracing benefit works because it reads the structure rather than the presentation. It also works reflexively — the fastest way to understand why someone is pressing you is to ask what your yes is worth to them, and the fastest way to be persuaded honestly is to ask what your no costs you.

TELLS

- The person proposing an arrangement describes your benefit at length and their own not at all.
- Terms favourable to you are argued for rather than simply stated.
- Someone's position changes when their incentives change, with no change in their reasoning.
- A third party with no visible stake is unusually invested in the outcome.
- The arrangement is complicated in a way that obscures who pays.

MOVES

1. For every proposal, write down who gains, who pays, and when each happens.
2. Check whether the gainer is the person explaining the arrangement.
3. Trace the money or the credit through every intermediary before forming a view.
4. Ask directly what the other party gets. The tone of the answer matters less than whether the question was expected.
5. Assume a proposer has a gain — nobody spends effort on an arrangement that does not benefit them.

COUNTERS

- Trace the benefit before evaluating the argument. An argument you cannot fault from a party who gains either way is not evidence of good faith.
- Require the terms in a form that shows who pays what. Complexity that survives a request to simplify is usually doing work for someone.
- Ask what the proposer would do if you said no. Their answer reveals the value of your yes.
- Be suspicious of arrangements where your benefit is asserted rather than demonstrated by the terms.

COST

Interest-tracing produces a cynical baseline, and the baseline is often wrong: people act from loyalty, confusion, principle and

mistake at least as often as from gain. Used as a proof rather than as a question it generates confident misreadings and costs relationships. It is also weakest exactly where it feels strongest — inside long relationships, where benefit flows are diffuse, mutual and poorly measured, and where the assumption of hidden gain does the most damage.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-03-02, T-05-01, T-25-01

Chapter 6

Tells and Consistency

Behaviour that can be filmed

*Detection rules that do not depend on intuition or on liking someone.
Everything here is observable, repeatable, and checkable against a second observation.*

6.1 Protest Too Much

Insistence is evidence

CORE

A quality that has to be asserted repeatedly is usually being asserted because it is absent. Honest people do not advertise honesty, solvent people do not mention solvency, and a person who keeps returning to their own reliability is managing a doubt they know is there.

MECHANISM

Two things produce over-assertion, and they are hard to separate. The first is discomfort: a person who knows a statement is false

over-compensates, because the ordinary level of emphasis feels insufficient to carry it. The second is selling: a person proposing an arrangement in which the terms do not demonstrate their good faith must supply the demonstration verbally. In both cases the volume of the claim is doing work that evidence would otherwise do. The tell is therefore not the claim itself but the mismatch between the claim's intensity and the available support — favourable terms, a verifiable history, a written agreement.

TELLS

- Trustworthiness is asserted before it is questioned.
- The same assurance is repeated in nearly identical words.
- Gratitude and warmth are expressed at length in advance of any benefit received.
- Your gain is restated several times by the person proposing the arrangement.
- The assurance is emotional rather than factual: tone carries it, not evidence.
- Physical warmth increases at the point where the commitment is requested.

MOVES

1. Supply the assurance yourself, unprompted and repeatedly, where the terms do not demonstrate good faith.
2. Attach the assurance to a moment of request rather than to a moment of information.
3. Restate the other party's benefit until it substitutes for evidence of it.

4. Increase warmth as the commitment approaches.

COUNTERS

- Do not argue with the assertion. Ask for the evidence it is replacing: references, a written term, a verifiable history, a small first transaction.
- Separate the claim from the deal. Evaluate the terms as though the assurance had never been made.
- Treat repeated assurance as a request to stop checking, and check more.
- Delay. Over-assertion is time-sensitive; a person selling certainty degrades visibly when asked to wait.
- Notice your own over-assertion. If you find yourself insisting on your good faith, you have already lost the position you are defending.

COST

The tell has a high false-positive rate in two populations: anxious people, who over-explain generally, and people who have been badly treated before, who pre-emptively defend themselves. Neither is lying. It is also useless against the skilled operator, who supplies exactly the ordinary amount of emphasis and lets the structure of the deal do the persuading — which is why this test must be combined with T-05-02 rather than used alone.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-03-02, T-05-02, T-06-02

6.2 The Two-Tellings Test

Consistency across time is the cheapest honesty check

CORE

Let a person tell the same story twice, at different times, and compare the details. A true account is stable in its specifics and varies in its framing; an invented one varies in its specifics because the specifics are being regenerated to suit whatever the current purpose is.

MECHANISM

A remembered event is retrieved as a whole, so its concrete details — who was there, what order things happened in, what was said — come back the same each time even when emphasis and interpretation change. A constructed account is assembled on demand, and assembly is driven by present need; the details shift because they were never stored, only chosen. Habitual construction makes this worse rather than better, because a person who routinely reshapes stories to fit the moment loses track of what was said before. The test is cheap because it requires no confrontation and no expertise — only memory and a second occasion.

TELLS

- Names, dates, amounts or sequences differ between tellings.
- The story improves: each version is more favourable to the teller than the last.
- Detail density changes — one version is rich in irrelevant specifics, another is vague where the first was precise.
- The moral of the story changes with the audience.

- Challenges to a specific are met with irritation rather than with recall.

MOVES

1. Ask the same question twice, separated by time, in different contexts.
2. Record the specifics the first time. Do not signal that you are recording them.
3. Compare specifics, not impressions. Framing differences are ordinary; factual differences are not.
4. Where the account has shifted, ask about the specific rather than the story, and observe whether the response is recall or reconstruction.

COUNTERS

- Apply it to your own accounts before applying it to anyone else's. Most people's ordinary inaccuracies are larger than they expect.
- Do not use a single mismatch as a verdict. Memory genuinely degrades and genuinely reconstructs; the test reads a pattern across several specifics, not one slip.
- If you are being tested, notice that the same ground is being covered twice and answer the second time by reference to the first rather than from fresh recall.
- Prefer documents. Where a record exists, consistency testing is unnecessary.

COST

It requires repeated contact, so it is useless in one-off dealings — which is where most losses occur. It also fails in two directions: an honest person under stress, or telling a story they were not present for, produces exactly the same drift; and a careful liar who keeps a consistent script passes it easily. It is a screening test with modest accuracy, not a determination, and treating it as the latter produces false accusations against nervous people.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-06-01, T-06-03, T-07-02

6.3 The Third-Party Lie Rule

How they treat someone else tells you how they will treat you

CORE

Watch a person lie to, or cheat, or dismiss someone who is not you. Their conduct toward third parties is not a separate department of their character; it is the same rule they will apply to you once your classification changes.

MECHANISM

People operate from an internal code that determines whom it is acceptable to deceive. The code is rarely organised around persons; it is organised around categories — people who matter, people who do not, people who can retaliate, people who cannot. You are currently in a favourable category, which is why you are seeing the good behaviour rather than the code. Categories are reassignable at low cost, and the reassignment happens the moment you stop being useful or start being inconvenient.

Observing a third party being mistreated is therefore a direct observation of the rule that will govern you later, taken at the only time it is visible.

TELLS

- They lie to someone in front of you, and then assure you that you are different.
- Service staff, subordinates and strangers are treated noticeably worse than people who can affect them.
- An absent third party is described in terms that make exploiting them sound reasonable.
- Loyalty is offered as a special exemption from a general practice.
- They recount past deceptions of others with approval rather than with discomfort.

MOVES

1. Establish a category boundary with the target — friend, outsider, adversary — and behave by category rather than by person.
2. Offer the counterpart a privileged position inside the category system.
3. Demonstrate the practice on someone else first, where the cost of demonstration is low.
4. Explain the practice as a response to how the world works rather than as a choice.

COUNTERS

-
- Treat observed conduct toward third parties as data about you, on a delay.
 - Reject special-exemption offers. A claim that you would be treated differently, from a person who treats others badly, is a statement about your current category rather than about their character.
 - Ask how they describe people they have fallen out with. The description is a rehearsal.
 - Assume your category will change, and structure commitments so that it does not matter — written terms, no dependence, an exit that does not require their cooperation.

COST

Everyone is harsher with some people than others, and a single observation proves little; the rule reads a settled pattern, not an incident. It is also asymmetric in a way that matters — being treated well by someone who treats others badly is genuinely pleasant and genuinely unstable, which makes the observation hard to act on. Finally the rule is unavailable in exactly the situation it is most needed: the operator will not mistreat a third party in front of a mark they are still working.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-03-02, T-06-01, T-06-04

6.4 Behaviour Over Declaration

What a person does is the only statement they cannot edit

CORE

Words are chosen for effect and can be revised at no cost. Conduct is expensive to fake over time. Where the two disagree, the disagreement is the information — and the declaration is the less reliable of the pair.

MECHANISM

Declarations are cheap because they are produced for an audience and cost the speaker nothing. Conduct is expensive because it is repeated, observable by many people over time, and inconsistent with hidden intentions in ways that eventually show. A person can maintain a stated position indefinitely; maintaining a contradictory pattern of action is much harder. This is why the reliable reading is always the longitudinal one — behaviour sampled across situations and across time — and why a single conversation, however revealing it feels, is weak evidence. It is also why demonstration beats argument: an action that changes someone's position without a word leaves no grievance and no counter-argument to work against.

TELLS

- A person's stated values predict nothing about their actual choices.
- Commitments are made fluently and met loosely.
- Their account of their own conduct is consistently more generous than other people's accounts of it.
- You find yourself persuaded by what they said rather than by what happened.
- The gap widens under pressure rather than closing.

MOVES

-
1. Sample behaviour across at least three different situations before forming a view, including one where the person has something to lose.
 2. Where you need agreement, produce a result rather than an argument.
 3. Say less than the situation invites, and let your actions carry the position.
 4. Where you must state a position, state it once and then demonstrate it rather than repeating it.

COUNTERS

- Weigh the last six months of what someone did above everything they said this week.
- Ask for a small, cheap, immediate action that follows from their declaration. Refusal or delay on something trivial is more diagnostic than any explanation.
- Track commitments in writing. The pattern emerges by itself and does not need to be argued about.
- Do not accept a revised account of past conduct as evidence about future conduct.

COST

Behaviour is also interpretable, and interpretations differ — a person may be unreliable rather than dishonest, constrained rather than unwilling. Reading conduct requires context that outsiders often lack, and the confident behaviourist is frequently just as wrong as the credulous listener, only later. The rule also breaks down for one-off interactions, which have no longitudinal

record to read; there, structural protections matter more than any judgement of character.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-06-01, T-06-03, T-16-01, T-23-01

Chapter 7

Gathering Information

Listening as an instrument

How information is obtained from a person who does not intend to give it, without the exchange turning into an interrogation.

7.1 Posing as a Friend

Social occasions are collection opportunities

CORE

The most efficient intelligence gathering does not look like gathering. It happens inside ordinary, pleasant, reciprocal social contact, where the counterpart is cooperating because they believe the exchange is mutual.

MECHANISM

People disclose in proportion to perceived safety and reciprocity. A social frame supplies both: nobody is being interrogated, the setting is low-stakes, and the norm of mutual disclosure means that a small confidence offered first obliges one in return. Direct

questioning breaks the frame and raises defences; the same information obtained inside a friendly exchange costs nothing and leaves no residue. The technique scales because social occasions are frequent and because the collector is not required to be anyone's friend — only to occupy the position where friendship is assumed.

TELLS

- Someone new takes a specific interest in your work, your grievances or your plans, without a reason to.
- They disclose something mildly damaging about themselves early, which obliges reciprocity.
- Questions arrive inside stories rather than as questions.
- They remember details you mentioned once, and use them to open the next conversation.
- The relationship has no other content — no shared task, no mutual friends, no reason to exist.

MOVES

1. Attend the ordinary occasions where your counterpart is relaxed.
2. Open with a small disclosure of your own. Reciprocity does the rest.
3. Embed questions in anecdotes so that answering does not feel like answering.
4. Ask indirectly about the thing you actually want, and let the answer drift toward it.

5. Keep notes afterwards, not during.
6. Use intermediaries where direct contact would be noticed.

COUNTERS

- Notice relationships that have no content other than conversation about you.
- Match disclosure level for level and do not exceed it. Reciprocity is a norm you can obey minimally.
- Answer embedded questions literally and briefly, then return the topic to them.
- Assume anything said socially will be repeated somewhere else, and price your remarks accordingly — especially grievances, which are the most useful thing you can hand over.
- Where a specific person keeps appearing, ask a mutual contact what the interest is. The answer is usually available.

COST

It is slow, and slowness is fatal where the decision window is short. It also produces a great deal of low-quality material, since relaxed people mostly talk about nothing; the skill is in filtering, and the filter is expensive in time. There is a further cost the source does not dwell on: a person who habitually treats social contact as collection ends up with no social contact, which is the isolation failure described in T-03-01 and priced in T-27-01.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-07-02, T-13-02, T-27-01

7.2 The Indirect Question

Ask beside the thing you want to know

CORE

A direct question about a sensitive subject produces a prepared answer. The same information obtained from an adjacent question — about a similar case, a third party, a hypothetical — produces an unprepared one.

MECHANISM

Preparation is topic-specific. A person who has thought about how to answer whether they intend to leave has not thought about how to answer what they would do if someone in their position left. The adjacent question routes around the prepared answer while keeping the underlying disposition engaged, and it does so without triggering the defensiveness that a direct approach causes. Two variants work particularly well: asking about a third party, which lets the respondent project their own view safely, and asking for advice, which invites them to state the reasoning they would otherwise conceal.

TELLS

- Someone asks your opinion about a case that resembles your situation closely.
- You are asked what you would do, or what you advise, about something that concerns them.
- A question about a third party has an oddly specific shape.
- The asker reacts to your answer rather than continuing the conversation.

- Questions cluster around one subject across several unrelated conversations.

MOVES

1. Move one step sideways: ask about someone like them, someone near them, or a hypothetical.
2. Ask for advice on a decision that is theirs. Advice-givers reveal their own criteria.
3. Ask about a third party's comparable situation and let them generalise.
4. Follow the reaction, not the words: hesitation and correction are more informative than content.
5. Stop after one indirect question on a subject. Two is a pattern they will notice.

COUNTERS

- Notice the sideways step. When a question is adjacent to something sensitive, answer the adjacent question and not the underlying one.
- Answer hypothetically in kind: give a general view that commits you to nothing specific.
- Reverse it — ask what prompted the question. Genuine curiosity survives that question; collection does not.
- Track clustering. A single indirect question is conversation; several around one subject across time is a campaign.

COST

Indirection produces indirect information. The respondent may answer the adjacent question honestly while the real position stays hidden, and projecting a view onto a third party is not the same as holding it. There is also a reciprocity cost: people who are habitually asked sideways eventually notice, and the noticing damages the relationship the information came from. The method is strongest on dispositions and weakest on facts, which are better obtained from documents.

Drawn from: B3, B1

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-07-01, T-07-03, T-05-01

7.3 The Three-Second Read

The involuntary response precedes the managed answer

CORE

Between a question and its answer there is a short window in which the face has not yet been arranged. What appears in that window is closer to the person's actual position than anything they subsequently say.

MECHANISM

Answering takes work: the content must be selected, the framing chosen, the delivery managed. That work takes a second or two, and before it completes, the immediate affective response to the question is already visible — surprise, recognition, fear, relief, anger. The response is to the question, not to the answer being constructed, which is what makes it informative. Reading it requires that the question be asked directly and suddenly enough that no prepared answer exists, and that the observer be looking

at the right place at the right moment rather than listening for the words.

TELLS

- A micro-expression of recognition when a name or subject is introduced.
- A beat of silence before an answer that should have been immediate.
- The eyes and upper face move before the mouth does.
- Relief rather than engagement when the subject is dropped.
- An answer that does not match the expression that preceded it.

MOVES

1. Introduce the subject indirectly first, then ask the direct question once, cleanly.
2. Look at the eye region and upper cheekbones, not the mouth.
3. Read the first three seconds and then stop reading. Later expressions are managed.
4. Compare the expression against the answer. Mismatch is the finding.
5. Do not follow up immediately. The value of the read is lost if the counterpart knows it happened.

COUNTERS

-
- Assume your face answers before you do, particularly on subjects that matter to you.
 - Introduce a deliberate pause before answering anything unexpected; a uniform delay is uninformative in a way that a natural reaction is not.
 - Answer the first version of the question and let the follow-up arrive later, when you have had time.
 - Where you are watched closely, control the setting rather than the face: move, eat, face a light, involve other people.
 - Do not over-trust your own reads. You are much worse at this than you believe, and confident misreading is worse than no reading.

COST

This is the least reliable entry in the chapter and the one most prone to confident error. Expression reading has a poor evidence base in general; cultural, individual and situational variation is large; and the observer's expectations generate the readings they expect to see. The source presents it as dependable, which is not supported. Its usable form is narrow: a mismatch between a clear expression and a clear answer, on a subject you already know matters, from someone you observe often. Outside that it should not change a decision on its own.

Drawn from: B1

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-06-02, T-07-01, T-07-02

Chapter 8

Judging Who You Are Dealing With

Choosing the engagement

The decision that precedes every tactic: whether to engage this person at all. Most losses in this domain come from engaging the wrong counterpart, not from executing badly against the right one.

8.1 Do Not Offend the Wrong Person

The cost of engagement depends entirely on who you engage

CORE

Most losses in this domain come from choosing the counterpart badly rather than from executing badly. Some people respond to being outmanoeuvred by forgetting it; others spend the rest of their lives on it, and you cannot tell which by looking at how they behave toward you today.

MECHANISM

The variance in response to a slight is enormous and is not visible from the front. Ordinary people absorb small defeats and move on; the dispositions described in T-03-01 do not, and their response is delayed, disproportionate and sustained. Because the response is delayed, the person who caused it usually has no idea it is coming and no idea what caused it — the offence was minor, the interaction ended amiably, and the account was opened anyway. The practical consequence is that selection matters more than technique: an average move against a safe counterpart beats a brilliant move against a dangerous one.

TELLS

- Disproportionate reaction to something minor, especially in public.
- Coldness at the time of an injury, followed by nothing — and then, much later, by something.
- A long, detailed memory of how they were treated.
- A history of conflicts with former colleagues, partners or friends, all of which were the other party's fault.
- Warmth that arrives very quickly, before there is anything to be warm about.

MOVES

1. Assume variance. Do not infer response type from the current interaction.
2. Gather history before engaging: how did this person handle the last person who crossed them?

3. Keep the cost of any move below the threshold at which a delayed account is opened.
4. Where you must oppose a dangerous counterpart, oppose the proposal rather than the person, and leave them a face-saving route.
5. Where you have already offended one, settle it completely and early. Partial settlement is worse than none.

COUNTERS

- Ask who this person has fallen out with, and how it ended. The answer is available and is the single most predictive thing about them.
- Do not assume you are the exception. Special-exemption claims are covered in T-06-03.
- Keep your own exposure low with anyone whose response type you have not yet observed under conflict — which is to say, with almost everyone, early on.
- If you are the person who has been offended, notice that delayed disproportionate response is expensive for you as well as for them, and settle or exit instead of accruing.

COST

It counsels caution to the point of paralysis if taken literally, since no counterpart's response type is fully observable in advance. It also has a moral cost: a policy of never offending the dangerous and freely offending the safe is a policy of predation on the people least able to defend themselves, and both sources eventually price that. The usable version is a screening rule — gather history, keep costs low, settle early — not a targeting rule.

Drawn from: B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-03-01, T-08-02, T-21-01

8.2 The Engagement Decision

Whether to play at all, made before the play

CORE

Before technique, before information, before framing, there is one decision: whether to engage this person about this thing at this time. It is the decision that determines most outcomes, and it is the one most often skipped because it happens before the conversation rather than inside it.

MECHANISM

Engagement is not neutral. Entering an exchange commits attention, reveals interest, opens a relationship that will need maintaining, and — if the counterpart is of the type described in T-08-01 — potentially opens an account that will be settled later. All of those costs are incurred whether or not you win. People skip the decision because it is not framed as one: the exchange arrives and they are in it. Making it explicit converts a default into a choice, and a choice can be declined at near-zero cost, which no later move can.

TELLS

- You are engaged because the other person initiated, not because you decided.
- You cannot state what you want from the exchange.

- The upside is small and the downside is open-ended.
- You are engaged out of curiosity, irritation, or an inability to let something stand.
- Winning would change nothing material.

MOVES

1. State the objective before the exchange. No objective, no engagement.
2. Estimate the upside, the downside, and the cost of the relationship afterwards.
3. Type the counterpart using T-03-01 and T-08-01 before deciding.
4. Check whether the timing is yours or theirs. An exchange on their schedule is already partly lost.
5. Where you decline, decline without explanation and without insult — both create the account you were avoiding.
6. Where you engage, engage fully. Half-engagement pays the costs and forfeits the benefits.

COUNTERS

- Reserve the right not to play. It is available far more often than it feels like, and the feeling that you must respond is usually manufactured.
- Answer a provocation with nothing. Attention withheld costs the provoker more than any reply, and costs you no account.

-
- Where you must engage, choose the ground and the time rather than accepting theirs.
 - Keep one alternative always available — another supplier, another job, another route — because the ability to walk away is what makes declining real.
 - Ask what happens if you simply do nothing. The answer is usually better than expected.

COST

Declining has costs that accumulate quietly: reputations for passivity, missed positions, and a pattern of conceding ground that others learn to exploit. Both sources note that non-engagement is itself a move with a payoff, and that payoff is not always positive. There is also a practical floor — some engagements are unavoidable, involving a manager, a relative, an institution — and for those the decision reduces to choosing the ground and limiting the exposure rather than declining.

Drawn from: B1, B3

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-03-01, T-08-01, T-21-02, T-24-02

Part III

Positioning

Power that exists before anybody speaks: reputation, attention, dependence, alliance, concealment. These are arrangements, not conversations, and they determine the outcome of most conversations before they start.

Chapter 9

Reputation

The asset that does most of the work

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 10

Attention, Absence and Scarcity

Value as a function of availability

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 11

Dependence

Being needed is a structure, not a sentiment

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 12

Alliances, Patrons and Courts

Where you stand, and who you stand with

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 13

Concealment and Indirection

Acting through what is not shown

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Part IV

Persuasion

Moving a mind without moving a muscle. Framing, appeal, demonstration, delivery. The cheapest and most reversible instruments in the book, and therefore the ones worth mastering first.

Chapter 14

Framing and Controlled Choice

Dealing the cards the other person plays

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

14.1 The Automatic Response

A single cue can fire a whole routine

CORE

Most compliance is not decided. A salient feature of the situation — a title, a queue, a deadline, a small gift — fires a rehearsed response that runs without the substance being evaluated. Whoever produces the feature steers the response and never has to win an argument.

MECHANISM

The routine exists because evaluating everything is unaffordable. Judging a request on its merits takes attention, information and time; most requests are ordinary, so a shortcut is normally correct. The shortcut is to find one feature that reliably predicts the whole and respond to the feature rather than to the thing.

That is efficient, and it is precisely what makes it exploitable: the feature can be manufactured far more cheaply than the condition it stands for. A credential is faster to fake than to earn, a crowd faster to assemble than to convince, a deadline faster to announce than to meet. Every principle in the rest of this book is a case of a predictable feature being produced on purpose, and the target's error is never stupidity — it is that the shortcut was correct often enough to be worth keeping.

TELLS

- You notice yourself agreeing before you have finished hearing the request.
- Your reason for saying yes is a single feature — the letterhead, the logo, the queue — rather than a weighing.
- The feature you relied on is cheap to produce and expensive to verify.
- Asked afterwards to reconstruct the decision, you cannot.

MOVES

1. Identify the one feature you intend the other party to respond to, and make sure it is present before you make the request.

2. Ask what it would cost you to fake that feature. If the answer is little, expect the other party to have faked it.
3. Make your own cues expensive to counterfeit: a verifiable record, a named reference, a real queue. A cue that cannot be borrowed cannot be stolen.

COUNTERS

- Separate the cue from the claim, and ask the question the cue was answering in terms the cue cannot answer.
- Delay. Automatic routines depend on momentum, and momentum does not survive an hour.
- Price the cue. Anything cheap to produce and hard to verify carries no information and should be discounted to zero.
- Name the routine to yourself while it is running.
Recognising a shortcut in use is most of disabling it.

COST

The shortcut is not a defect and cannot be removed without cost. A person who evaluates every cue from first principles cannot hire anyone, buy anything or cross a street, and is still wrong about most things — only slower and more exhausting about it. The usable rule is asymmetric: keep the shortcuts where being wrong is cheap, and treat cheap-to-fake cues as worthless exactly where it is not. The entry's epilogue case is that the volume of cues now arriving per hour has risen while the time to evaluate each has fallen, which moves more decisions into the first category whether or not anyone intends it.

FIELD NOTE

The same words on letterhead are read differently from the same words on a napkin, and the difference survives knowing perfectly well that letterhead costs nothing to print.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-14-02, T-01-01, T-18-01, T-23-01

14.2 The Contrast Principle

A second option is judged against the first, not on its own

CORE

Judgements are comparative. The same price, the same request and the same concession are evaluated differently depending on what was presented immediately before, so whoever chooses the order of presentation chooses a good part of the verdict.

MECHANISM

There is no absolute scale available for most decisions. What counts as a fair price, a large favour or a serious problem is not knowable in isolation, so the mind settles it by comparison with whatever was most recently in view. That makes the first item a measuring instrument rather than a candidate: it is frequently not meant to be accepted at all, and its function is to set the distance against which the second item looks small.

The principle is not confined to price. Severity, urgency and generosity all take their scale from the immediately preceding case, which is why an offer can be made to look reasonable without changing the offer — only what precedes it. The control lies entirely with the party who decides the sequence.

TELLS

- Two or more options arrive in a fixed order, and the first is described at length and then abandoned without any effort to sell it.
- You find the second option reasonable and cannot say what you are comparing it against.
- The comparison set is supplied entirely by the other party.
- An item you would have refused a week ago now looks modest.

MOVES

1. Set the anchor deliberately, and let it introduce the proposal you actually want accepted.
2. Present the expensive case first whenever the cheap case has to be accepted on its own terms.
3. Move in visible steps rather than arriving at your real position immediately; a position reached by stages is judged against the stages.

COUNTERS

- Ask for the options out of order, or for each one separately.
- Import your own comparison. Price the thing against the market, not against the alternative on the table.
- Evaluate the final proposal as though it were the first thing you had heard, which is what it would have been in an honest sequence.

-
- Notice the abandoned first option. An offer presented at length and then dropped without argument was probably never for sale.

COST

Anchoring is so ordinary that using it deliberately changes little in most transactions, and refusing to be anchored at all makes you slower and more suspicious than the situation calls for. The exposure worth guarding is narrow: it is where the anchor is far from the truth and the other party controls the entire comparison set. That is why the defence is to bring a comparison in from outside rather than to argue about the one on offer — arguing inside a frame accepts the frame.

FIELD NOTE

An agent who shows two unsuitable properties before the one she means to let has not wasted an afternoon; she has built the ruler the third will be measured against.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-14-01, T-15-01, T-25-01

Chapter 15

The Appeals

Self-interest, fantasy, and the need to believe

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 16

Argument and Demonstration

Winning without winning the argument

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

16.1 Concession and Retreat

A demand refused and then reduced gets more than the reduced demand alone

CORE

Open with a demand you expect refused, then withdraw it in favour of a smaller one. The smaller demand is granted at a rate it would not have achieved on its own, because the withdrawal is read as a concession and a concession invites one.

MECHANISM

Two principles combine and neither requires sincerity.

Reciprocity supplies the obligation: a move toward you creates a duty to move toward the other party, and reducing a demand is such a move whether or not the reduced demand was the intended one all along. Contrast supplies the calibration: the second demand is judged against the first rather than on its own, so it arrives already looking moderate.

The important property is that both respond to the *form* of the move rather than to the intent behind it. Knowing the sequence is scripted does not switch either off, which is why the technique survives being recognised. What it purchases is not agreement with a position but a felt duty to meet a halfway point that was never halfway.

TELLS

- The opening demand is larger than the other party could have expected you to accept.
- It is withdrawn quickly and without visible reluctance.
- The replacement is presented as a compromise.
- You feel you gained something by refusing and cannot say what.
- Both demands serve the same interest, and the second was available from the start.

MOVES

1. Open above your real target, and treat the opening as an instrument rather than as a position to be defended.
2. Retreat in one clear step. Several small reductions read as ordinary negotiation and lose the concession effect entirely.

3. Make the retreat visible and slightly costly-looking; a withdrawal that appears effortless invites no return.
4. Ask for the return in a different currency from the concession, so no direct comparison is available.

COUNTERS

- Re-classify the move: ask whether the second demand is a concession or simply the offer, and evaluate it as though it had arrived first.
- Decline to reciprocate a retreat that costs the other party nothing. A reduction that leaves their interest intact was never a concession.
- Test it with a retreat of your own. Reduce your position slightly and see whether they reduce again; a conciliator will, a script will not.
- Slow the exchange down. The duty to answer a concession is strongest inside a single conversation.
- Ask for the reduced demand in writing, on its own, dated. Detached from the opener it usually loses most of its force.

COST

The opener is exposed if the first demand is absurd, because an obviously planted anchor destroys the credibility of everything that follows — including the honest parts of the position. It also teaches the counterpart to read every later reduction as scripted, which removes its value in any negotiation that continues. Cheap once against a stranger; expensive repeatedly against someone you will meet again.

FIELD NOTE

A subscription pitched annually, declined, and replaced with a monthly one closes at a rate the monthly offer would not have closed had it been made first.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-14-02, T-19-01, T-24-01, T-16-02

Chapter 17

Delivery

Timing, boldness and effortlessness

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 18

Appearance and Compliance

Looking like the thing you are not

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Part V

Pressure

Hard tactics. They work faster than anything in Part IV and cost more than everything in it. Every entry here carries an unusually long limits slot, because the bill for pressure arrives later and is paid in kind.

Chapter 19

Guilt, Fear and Obligation

The soft pressures

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

19.1 The Uninvited Debt

An obligation does not require your consent

CORE

A benefit you never asked for, from someone you never chose, creates the same pressure to repay as one you negotiated — and usually more, because declining it reads as ingratitude rather than as a decision. Consent is not part of the mechanism.

MECHANISM

Reciprocity is enforced socially rather than contractually. The person who takes a benefit and returns nothing is marked, and the marking is public. That makes the rule hard to opt out of, because the opt-out is itself visible and is read as a verdict on character.

So the operative fact is not the value of the benefit but its occurrence. An unrequested favour installs an account whose balance was never agreed, whose repayment date is chosen by the creditor, and whose currency the creditor will nominate later. Critically, the repayment need have nothing to do with the original benefit: the account is not a trade, it is a standing obligation, and it can be drawn on for any request the holder likes to make. Choosing the form and timing of the benefit is what gives the holder control over the draw.

TELLS

- A benefit arrives that you would have declined had you been asked.
- The giver chose its form, its size and its timing.
- The request that follows is unrelated to the benefit and larger than it.
- Refusing produces a feeling about yourself rather than a calculation about the transaction.
- The benefit is mentioned — by the giver or by a third party — shortly before the request.

MOVES

1. Give first, on your own terms, and keep accounts small and closed; an open balance is an asset to whoever holds it.

2. Choose a benefit that is genuinely useful and unmistakably voluntary, so that its reality cannot later be disputed.
3. Decide the request you will make before the benefit is given, and make it in a different currency from the benefit.
4. Never name the debt. Naming converts an asset into a grievance and releases the other party from it.

COUNTERS

- Refuse early and politely, in the same breath as the offer. Once acceptance has been observed, the only remaining question is the size of the repayment, and the other party sets it.
- Where refusal is impossible, repay at once, specifically, and in a form you choose. A closed account cannot be drawn on.
- Split the two questions — *was I helped?* and *does this request follow from it?* — and answer the second on its own.
- Price the benefit at what it cost the giver, not at what it is worth to you.
- Make the refusal short and unexplained. A reason offered is a reason to be argued with.

COST

Refusing every unsolicited benefit produces a person who cannot accept help and reads all generosity as an opening move, which is its own captivity and costs real relationships. The rule worth holding is narrow: scrutinise where the benefit was unrequested, large relative to the relationship, or followed quickly by an unrelated ask. Elsewhere let the account stand — ordinary reciprocity is what makes cooperation affordable in the first place.

FIELD NOTE

A clipboard, a flower pressed into a hand, an audit offered free of charge: the benefit is chosen so that declining it in public costs more than accepting it.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-04-02, T-19-02, T-24-01, T-16-01

19.2 Unequal Exchange

The repayment need not resemble the debt

CORE

A small benefit can be traded for a much larger one, and the trade usually goes through. The pressure generated is to repay, not to repay equally, and nothing in the mechanism sets an exchange rate.

MECHANISM

The account carries no stated amount and no stated currency, so the debtor settles it by reference to a feeling rather than to an arithmetic of equivalence. That leaves the size of the repayment to be proposed by the creditor, who has every reason to propose large.

Two forces reinforce the asymmetry. The first is discomfort: an unsettled account is unpleasant to hold, and the quickest way to be rid of the feeling is to agree to whatever is asked, which makes the yes a relief rather than a decision. The second is exposure: not reciprocating is publicly marked, so the debtor is not merely uncomfortable but visibly so, and even a lopsided repayment clears the marking. Because both forces respond to the fact of the

debt and not to its size, the disproportion is never felt as a reason to refuse.

TELLS

- The request is far larger than the benefit, and the disproportion goes unremarked.
- You experience owing a decision rather than owing a comparable favour.
- Agreeing relieves a feeling more than it achieves an outcome.
- The benefit was chosen by the other party and costs them little to give.
- No price was ever attached to the benefit, and attaching one now feels rude.

MOVES

1. Keep the opening benefit small, cheap for you to give and visibly personal; the exchange rate is set by the feeling, not by the value.
2. Ask for the larger thing soon afterwards, and in a different currency, so that no comparison is available to the other party.
3. Leave the benefit unpriced. A benefit that has been costed has already been repaid.

COUNTERS

- Insist on the arithmetic. Establish what the benefit was worth, repay in kind and promptly, and treat the account as closed.

-
- Name the disproportion plainly and without accusation: this is considerably larger than what you did for me.
 - Delay. The discomfort driving the unequal exchange decays faster than the obligation itself.
 - Choose the repayment currency rather than accepting the one offered.
 - Ask what the benefit cost the giver. A cheap gift demanding an expensive return is a transaction, not a kindness, and can be treated as one.

COST

Pushed too far the technique brands its user: a person known for trading small kindnesses into large concessions finds the marking that makes reciprocity work running against them, and later benefits are refused at the door. It also fails outright where the account is not meant to be settled at all — family, long colleagues — because proposing an exchange rate in such a relationship is itself the offence, and the offence outlasts the concession.

FIELD NOTE

A free sample is not a gift of product. It is the opening of an account whose intended repayment is a purchase, and whose size is set at the till rather than at the counter.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-19-01, T-04-02, T-25-01, T-24-01

Chapter 20

Coercion and the Dirty Way

The hard pressures, and their price

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 21

Conflict

Enemies, surrender, retaliation

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 22

Working the Hearts

Seduction rather than force

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Part VI

Defence

*The half of the book that pays for itself. Detection, refusal, money, exit.
A reader who is currently being worked on should start here and go
backwards.*

Chapter 23

Detection

Reading it live

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 24

Inoculation and Refusal

Answers that do not require winning

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

24.1 Refusing an Unauthorised Debt

Declining the premise rather than arguing the amount

CORE

The answer to an obligation you did not create is not to argue that you owe nothing. It is to decline the premise on which the obligation was built — promptly, politely, and without engaging the merits of the request that follows it.

MECHANISM

Arguing about the size of a debt concedes that a debt exists. The obligation is installed by the occurrence of a benefit rather than

by its value, so any discussion of value takes place inside the frame the other party built and can only ever adjust the amount.

What removes the frame is a decision taken before the request arrives: that an unrequested benefit opens no account. That decision is easy to hold and hard to execute, because the pressure is social and visible, and refusing looks like ingratitude to any audience. The refusal therefore has two halves — an internal reclassification, and an external form of words that does not turn the refusal into a verdict on the giver's character. Where the benefit genuinely cannot be refused, only the second half changes: repay it immediately, specifically, and in a currency of your own choosing, so that nothing remains outstanding to be drawn on later.

TELLS

- A benefit you did not request has arrived, and the giver chose its form and timing.
- A request follows that has no connection to the benefit.
- You are aware of feeling obliged before you have decided anything.
- Refusing would be observed by a third party.
- The benefit is referred to in the same conversation as the request.

MOVES

1. Decide the policy in advance, so that the decision is not made under pressure in front of an audience.
2. Decline in the same breath as the offer, before acceptance has been seen by anyone.

3. Where decline is impossible, repay at once, name the amount, and state that the account is closed.
4. Answer the request separately and explicitly: these are two questions, and the first does not settle the second.
5. Keep the refusal short, warm and unexplained.

COUNTERS

- When the refusal is called ungrateful, agree that you are grateful and decline anyway. Gratitude and compliance are different things and can be stated separately.
- When the benefit is re-described as something you wanted, do not dispute the description; restate that you did not ask for it.
- When a third party applies the pressure, address them rather than the giver: the account, if there is one, is not theirs to collect.
- When the request is reduced after your refusal, treat the reduction as a new proposal and evaluate it on its own — see T-16-01.
- When you are offered a way to repay, take it, pay it in full, and consider the matter finished rather than continuing to negotiate.

COST

A refusal that is habitually applied makes you difficult to help, and people stop offering — which removes the ordinary goodwill that most relationships run on. The policy is therefore situational rather than absolute: it is aimed at benefits that were

unrequested, chosen by the giver, and followed quickly by an unrelated ask. Applied to genuine kindness it produces a person who is defended against nothing and isolated by the defence.

Drawn from: B4

Source dossiers for this entry are filed in Appendix A.

See also: T-19-01, T-19-02, T-16-01, T-04-02

Chapter 25

Money and Contracts

Where the losses actually happen

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 26

Exit and Aftermath

Disengaging cleanly

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Part VII

Cost

What the practice does to the practitioner, and what self-command is required before any of it is worth attempting.

Chapter 27

What You Get Out of Using People

The bill

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Chapter 28

Self-Mastery

The precondition

Entries in this chapter are not yet written. The scaffolding is in place; see the State of the Build appendix for what is outstanding.

Appendix A

Source Dossiers

One file per book per entry, filed in ingest order and never rewritten. This appendix is the audit trail: it shows what each source contributed and flags the material that exists in only one book and must never be dropped.

What Manipulation Actually Is

T-01-01 | The Five-Percent Premise

B1 | T-01-01

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: ch. 1, pp. 1–8

DISTILLED

- Framing claim of the book: about five percent of people manipulate the other ninety-five percent, and the difference is knowledge of human nature rather than intelligence.

- The author's stated method is to learn from practitioners — hustlers and con artists — rather than from academic psychology, on the ground that a tactic is only real if it works in the field.
- The chapter closes by turning the premise defensive: the point of learning the tactics is to stop being on the receiving end of them.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The five-percent figure itself, and the framing of manipulation as a learnable trade acquired from practitioners rather than from theory.

VOCABULARY

- *street-educated mind* — Sparkman's term for judgment acquired from repeated losses rather than from study.

B3 | T-01-01

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: preface; ch. Amoral power

DISTILLED

- Power is presented as a game that runs whether or not you choose to play, and refusing to play is itself a move with consequences.
- The book addresses the practitioner and the target in the same voice, on the argument that the techniques are identical from both sides of the table.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The explicit amoral framing: the mechanics of power are treated as descriptive, and moral judgement is moved to the reader's choice of use.

B4 | T-01-01

Cialdini, Influence (1984) • locator: intro, pp. 1–12; ch. 1, pp. 13–42

DISTILLED

- The distribution is explained rather than merely asserted: the operating minority succeeds because most responses are not deliberated, so a person who produces the cue does not have to defeat the target's judgement.
- The author's own standing as a repeated target is offered as the reason for the enquiry, and the method is infiltration — learning the techniques from inside the trades that use them.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The causal account of the asymmetry. B1 and B3 both state that a minority operates and a majority is operated on; neither explains why the majority does not simply resist. B4 supplies the answer, and it is not a deficit of intelligence.
- Infiltration as a research method: acquiring the technique by taking the job, which is a distinctive stance toward evidence.

T-01-02 | Three Different Activities

B1 | T-01-02

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: ch. 1 and ch. 12–13

DISTILLED

- Sparkman separates talking someone into something from arranging the situation so they talk themselves into it; his tactics are overwhelmingly the second kind.
- The pressure tactics (12 and 13) are treated as a distinct, last-resort register — a little pressure has its place but seldom — which is coercion, not manipulation, and is priced accordingly.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The explicit ranking of registers: manipulate by arrangement first, apply pressure rarely, and treat the openly dirty method as a last resort with a known cost.

B3 | T-01-02

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 43; Law 9

DISTILLED

- Working on hearts and minds is preferred to force because coercion produces a reaction that eventually turns against the user.
- Winning through argument is rejected as a Pyrrhic result: the resentment outlasts the change of opinion. Demonstration is preferred to explication.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The durability argument: consent obtained by working on a person's own psychology persists without maintenance, while compliance obtained by force must be enforced continuously.

B4 | T-01-02

Cialdini, Influence (1984) • locator: ch. 1, pp. 13–42

DISTILLED

- The three activities differ in what the target is left holding, and the mechanism view sharpens the line: an edited picture can be delivered by one manufactured feature rather than by an argument, which is what makes manipulation cheap and difficult to detect from inside.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The delivery mechanism for the edited picture. B1 and B3 distinguish the activities; B4 explains how the edit is installed without an argument being offered or refuted.

T-01-03 | Power as an Amoral Instrument

B3 | T-01-03

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: preface; Laws 18, 20

DISTILLED

- Power is treated descriptively, as an observable set of dynamics, with moral judgement left to the reader's choice of application.
- The court is used as the model system: a closed hierarchy where advancement depends on managing perception, dependence and timing.

- Isolation is explicitly priced as a strategic error rather than a refuge — a fortress cuts you off from information and makes you a conspicuous target.
- Non-commitment is treated as an available and often superior position: staying unattached preserves optionality and lets others compete for you.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The court as the canonical model of power dynamics, and the argument that isolation is a cost rather than a protection.

VOCABULARY

- *the court* — any closed hierarchy in which advancement depends on the perception of superiors rather than on output alone.
- *reversal* — the section of each law stating when the law should be broken; the book's built-in correction against applying a rule mechanically.

T-01-04 | Intent Is the Only Ethical Switch

B1 | T-01-04

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: ch. 1, closing; ch. 16

DISTILLED

- The ethics of the tactic set are located in intent rather than in the technique: the same moves serve self-defence and exploitation.

-
- The stated purpose of teaching them is to equip the reader to recognise and refuse malicious use.
 - The final chapter prices the practice: what a person ends up with after using people for their own ends.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The closing cost chapter, which treats the outcome for the practitioner as part of the technique's description rather than as a moral aside.

B2 | T-01-04

Bookey summary of Sparkman • locator: ch. 1 summary; ch. 15

DISTILLED

- Corroborates B1: the summary records the ethics discussion as turning on intent, with the reader empowered to defend against malicious use.
- Corroborates the cost chapter as a distinct closing unit rather than an afterword.

T-01-05 | Results Are the Only Test

B1 | T-01-05

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: ch. 1

DISTILLED

- Effectiveness is stated as the sole evaluation criterion for a tactic: it must work in practice.

- The author's education is described as coming from practitioners — hustlers and con artists — rather than from academic sources, on the ground that theory had not produced usable method.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The explicit rejection of academic framing in favour of field effectiveness, as the book's stated epistemology.

VOCABULARY

- *the nut* — a business's fixed monthly overhead; used later as the constraint on how independent a person can afford to appear.

B3 | T-01-05

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: preface; structure of each law

DISTILLED

- Each law is supported by historical cases of transgression and observance, i.e. argued from outcomes rather than from principle.
- The reversal section of each law states when the rule should be broken, which is an acknowledgement that outcome-based rules are context-bound.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The transgression/observance/reversal case structure as an argumentative form: a rule is justified by what happened to people who broke it and to people who kept it, then bounded by the conditions under which it inverts.

The Practitioner's Equipment

T-02-01 | Affect Control

B3 | T-02-01

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 39, pp. 325–332; Law 43

DISTILLED

- Anger and emotion are treated as strategically counterproductive for the person feeling them; the instruction is to stay calm and objective at all times.
- The same law turns offensive: making an opponent angry while remaining calm yourself is described as a decisive advantage, obtained by finding the thread in their vanity.
- Working on hearts and minds is preferred to coercion because coerced compliance generates a reaction that later turns against the user.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The two-directional treatment of affect: self-composure and provoking the opponent's emotion are presented as one technique with two ends, and vanity is named as the usual thread.

T-02-02 | Indifference to Being Liked

B1 | T-02-02

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 5, pp. 59–70; Tactic 2, pp. 19–30

DISTILLED

- Retaliation is argued against on effectiveness grounds: harsh words produce more harsh words, and an ego injury creates a resentful enemy who is expensive later.
- The clever putdown is identified as a fantasy imported from film; in practice it raises resistance rather than clearing it.
- The meekness tactic is paired with concealing how much you know — appearing less formidable makes people talk.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The explicit anti-retaliation argument, including the observation that winning a verbal exchange produces a worse net outcome than losing it, because the loser becomes a persistent adversary.

B3 | T-02-02

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 9, pp. 69–75

DISTILLED

- Argument produces a Pyrrhic result: the resentment outlasts the change of opinion.
- Demonstration is preferred to explication — agreement obtained through actions rather than words does not carry a grievance with it.

T-02-03 | Patience as Position

B3 | T-02-03

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 35, pp. 291–299

DISTILLED

-
- Hurrying is described as betraying a lack of control over yourself and over time; the instruction is to appear patient, as though everything will arrive eventually.
 - The practitioner is told to become a detective of the right moment and to read the spirit of the times.
 - The skill is stated as a pair: stand back when the time is not ripe, strike fiercely when it is.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- Timing treated as a learnable perceptual skill — detecting the ripe moment — rather than as a matter of waiting passively.

T-02-04 | Effortlessness

B3 | T-02-04

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 30, pp. 245–251

DISTILLED

- Actions must appear natural and easy; the toil, the practice and the clever tricks behind them are concealed.
- Revealing how hard you work is described as raising questions rather than earning credit.
- The instruction ends with a warning about teaching: reveal your tricks and they will be used against you.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The explicit link between concealing method and security — a visible method is a method that can be turned back on its owner.

T-02-05 | Persistence Over Attitude

B1 | T-02-05

Sparkman, *Art of Manipulation* (1978) • locator: Tactic 7, pp. 77–88

DISTILLED

- Positive attitude is compared to a gigolo: comfortable and sustaining until hard times arrive, at which point it disappears.
- The argument is that you can decide to be persistent and carry the decision out through failure, but you cannot decide to hold an attitude through failure.
- Surface attitude — affirmation routines, self-addressed pep talk — produces temporary confidence that evaporates on contact with real losses.
- Group morale is distinguished from individual stamina: the winning attitude that transforms a team does not carry an individual afterwards.
- The chapter's title image contrasts a productive dairy breed with a large impressive-looking one: choose for yield, not for appearance.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The attitude-versus-persistence argument, including the group-to-individual transfer failure, and the yield-over-appearance selection rule drawn from livestock breeds.

VOCABULARY

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- *the Guernsey and the Brahma* — Sparkman's image for the choice between a productive but unimpressive option and an impressive but unproductive one.

Character Types

T-03-01 | The Five Dangerous Marks

B3 | T-03-01

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 19, pp. 137–147

DISTILLED

- A preliminary typology of opponents, suckers and victims; distinguishing types is described as the highest form of the art, because it removes the need to coerce.
- The arrogant and proud man: touchy pride, vengeance out of all proportion to the slight, no sanity behind the over-reaction. Instruction is to flee on sensing it.
- The hopelessly insecure man: related but less violent and harder to spot; hurt simmers and arrives as small bites over a long period. Instruction is to disappear for a long time.
- Mr. Suspicion: sees the worst in everyone, genuinely unbalanced and therefore easy to deceive, but dangerous if his suspicion turns on you.
- The serpent with a long memory: no surface anger, calculates and waits, settles with cold shrewdness. Recognised by calculation across areas of life and by coldness. Instruction: crush completely or get out of sight.

- The plain, unassuming and unintelligent man: hardest to deceive, because taking a ruse requires imagination and a sense of possible reward. The cost is wasted time and resources rather than revenge. Test with a joke or story; a wholly literal reaction identifies the type.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The full five-type typology, with the counter-intuitive finding that the apparently naive counterpart is the most expensive — not dangerous, but unreachable, so the loss is time rather than injury.
- The joke-or-story test as a cheap discriminator for the literal type.

VOCABULARY

- *mark* — the intended victim of a scheme.
- *wolves from lambs* — the book's shorthand for the whole task of typing a counterpart before engaging.

T-03-02 | The Operator Profile

B1 | T-03-02

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 1, pp. 9–18

DISTILLED

- Character types to watch out for, drawn from the author's direct experience of being defrauded repeatedly by people he liked.
- The over-reassurer: every con artist took pains to assert his trustworthiness before the loss, using variations on the same formula — you will not regret this, I have always paid you, you can count on me.

-
- A running list of the author's own losses is given with the exact reassurance used in each case, which is the evidentiary basis of the type.
 - The once-wealthy man: nearly every operator had a story of money formerly held and lost.
 - Demonstrative gratitude and physical warmth — back-slapping, repeated assurance that you will get everything coming to you — are described as the position from which the knife goes in.
 - Terms that favour the target are said to speak for themselves; a person who repeats your benefit at length is selling something.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The over-reassurance pattern documented against the author's own recorded losses, with the operator's exact formulae, and the derived rule that favourable terms do not need to be argued.
- The once-wealthy story as a distinct type marker rather than as background detail.

VOCABULARY

- *protest too much* — asserting a quality so insistently that the assertion itself becomes the evidence against it.

Load-Bearing Points

T-04-01 | The Thumbscrew

B3 | T-04-01

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 33, pp. 281–290

DISTILLED

- Everyone has a weakness, described as a gap in the castle wall.
- The gap is usually an insecurity, an uncontrollable emotion or need, or a small secret pleasure.
- Once found it functions as a thumbscrew that can be turned to advantage.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The specific enumeration of what the weak point usually is — insecurity, uncontrollable emotion, need, or small secret pleasure — rather than a general claim that everyone has one.
- The naming of the device as a thumbscrew: incremental pressure applied to a small point rather than force applied to the whole person.

VOCABULARY

- *thumbscrew* — a small, repeatable pressure applied to a known weak point.
- *gap in the castle wall* — the single undefended place in an otherwise defended person.

T-04-02 | The Favour Debt

B1 | T-04-02

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 14, pp. 167–176

DISTILLED

-
- Ingratitude is treated as a predictable outcome rather than as a moral failure, and the chapter is about preventing it in advance rather than punishing it afterwards.
 - The premise is that a benefit conferred creates an expectation which the recipient experiences as pressure, and that pressure converts into resentment if it is left unstated.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- Framing ingratitude as a structural problem with a preventive technique, rather than as a character judgement about the recipient.

B3 | T-04-02

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 13, pp. 95–101; Law 12; Law 40

DISTILLED

- When asking for help, appeal to the other party's self-interest and never to their mercy or their gratitude; reminding an ally of your past assistance gives them a way to ignore you.
- Find something in the request that benefits them and emphasise it out of proportion.
- Selective honesty and generosity are described as a way to lower a suspicious person's guard — a timely gift opens a hole in the armour.
- The free lunch is to be despised: what is offered for nothing usually carries a trick or a hidden obligation, and paying your own way keeps you clear of gratitude, guilt and deceit.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The instruction to appeal to self-interest rather than to gratitude, with the reason that a reminded debtor finds a way to ignore you.
- Paying full price as a deliberate strategy for staying outside other people's accounts.

B4 | T-04-02

Cialdini, Influence (1984) • locator: ch. 2, pp. 43–86

DISTILLED

- The favour debt is the strongest of the compliance levers because it is enforced by visible social marking rather than by any agreement between the parties.
- The account's undefined balance is not a weakness of the lever but its main feature: because no amount is stated, the creditor nominates the repayment.
- An unsettled account is unpleasant to hold, and relieving that state is itself a motive to comply with whatever is asked.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- Why the debt is hard to refuse: the enforcement is public marking, not private guilt. B1 treats gratitude as an unreliable instrument; B4 explains the pressure that makes it reliable in the moment even when it is unreliable later.
- Discomfort as an independent driver, separate from any calculation about the transaction.

T-04-03 | Vanity as a Handle

B1 | T-04-03

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 5; Tactic 10, pp. 117–124

DISTILLED

- Ego injury is identified as the trigger that produces persistent enemies, which is the practical reason for avoiding the clever putdown.
- Most arguments are said to be winnable by declining to contest the point that carries the other person's standing, and letting sleeping dogs lie where your vital interests are unaffected.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The rule of thumb that an argument should only be contested where it touches your vital interests, with everything else conceded as cheaper than the resentment.

B3 | T-04-03

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 1, pp. 1–7; Law 39

DISTILLED

- Displaying more talent than the person above you is described as inspiring fear and insecurity rather than admiration; the instruction is to make superiors appear more brilliant than they are.

- The reaction to a perceived slight is out of all proportion and there is no sanity behind it, so the counterparty should not be reasoned with.
- Finding the thread in an opponent's vanity and rattling it is presented as the way to take control of an exchange while staying calm yourself.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The specific mechanism by which visible competence in a junior threatens a senior — it is read as an intention to displace — and the resulting instruction to make the superior's brilliance visible rather than your own.

T-04-04 | The Self-Audit

B1 | T-04-04

Sparkman, *Art of Manipulation* (1978) • locator: Tactic 1; Tactic 6, pp. 71–76

DISTILLED

- The book's premise is that the reader is on the receiving end far more often than they realise, and that the remedy is to learn the tactics in order to recognise them.
- Determining a person's real motive is treated as a prerequisite to influencing them; the same reasoning applies reflexively to one's own motives.
- Knowing what obstacle actually stands in your way is presented as the difference between effective action and swinging in the dark.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The explicit instruction to learn the offensive material for defensive purposes, stated as the book's reason for existing.

B3 | T-04-04

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 33; Law 39; Law 48

DISTILLED

- The weak-point analysis is directed at the counterpart, but the same enumeration applies to the reader.
- Emotional reaction is identified as the thing that hands control to an opponent, which makes knowing your own triggers the precondition of the calm prescribed elsewhere.
- Formlessness — refusing to have a fixed shape an opponent can attack — is the end state of the same discipline.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- Formlessness as the terminal goal of self-knowledge: having no fixed shape is presented as the only durable defence, since a known point can always be loaded.

Motives Before Words

T-05-01 | The Real Objection

B1 | T-05-01

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 6, pp. 71–76

DISTILLED

- Picking a person apart to discover real motives and feelings is presented as the prerequisite of influencing them at all.
- The questions the practitioner must answer are stated plainly: why will he not sign, why will she not do what is asked.
- Without the real objection you do not know what obstacle stands in the way, and effort spent on the stated objection is described as swinging in the dark — most blows fall wide of the target.
- Finding the true objection is said to give you something you can actually work with.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The operational distinction between the stated and the real objection, and the diagnostic value of the stated one: effort directed at it misses, and the pattern of misses identifies the real target.

T-05-02 | Follow the Interest

B1 | T-05-02

Sparkman, *Art of Manipulation* (1978) • locator: Tactic 8, pp. 89–108; Tactic 3, pp. 31–42

DISTILLED

- Avoiding being taken in financial dealings is reduced to a single instruction: watch where the money goes.

-
- A person proposing a deal must have something to gain from it, or they would not spend the breath; the more they emphasise your gain, the more they stand to make at your expense.
 - Favourable terms are said to speak for themselves and to be offered with a take-it-or-leave-it stance, not argued at length.
 - Favouritism is treated as a standing feature of the world rather than an aberration, and therefore as something to understand and use rather than to complain about.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The volume rule: the amount of emphasis placed on your benefit is inversely related to how favourable the terms actually are.
- Favouritism as a normal structural feature of institutions rather than a corruption of them.

B3 | T-05-02

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 13, pp. 95–101; Law 7

DISTILLED

- Appeal to self-interest rather than to mercy or gratitude, because interest is something a person can act on immediately.
- Uncover what in your request benefits the other party and emphasise it out of proportion; they respond when they see something to gain.
- Using other people's work while taking the credit is presented as an economy of effort — never do yourself what

others can do for you — which is the same tracing of benefit applied to your own position.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The instruction to over-emphasise the counterpart's gain out of proportion, i.e. interest-tracing used offensively as a framing device rather than only as a diagnostic.

Tells and Consistency

T-06-01 | Protest Too Much

B1 | T-06-01

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 1, pp. 9–18

DISTILLED

- People who stress something too much are doubted by the experienced observer; the pattern is drawn from Shakespeare's protest-too-much observation and matched against the author's own losses.
- A liar soothe-talks in a too-reassuring, too-demonstrative way, over-compensating nervously for a lack of substance.
- The author lists the exact reassurances used by the people who defrauded him, each delivered immediately before the loss.
- Terms that genuinely favour the other party are said not to require selling; the proposer adopts a take-it-or-leave-it stance instead.

-
- The same dynamic is said to apply outside money: a person who must remind you of their trustworthiness is probably using you.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The over-compensation mechanism — nervous excess of emphasis substituting for absent substance — stated as the reason the tell works, rather than as a folk observation.
- Extension of the tell from financial dealings to personal relationships, where the same self-advertising of reliability appears.

VOCABULARY

- *protest too much* — asserting a quality so insistently that the assertion becomes evidence against it.

T-06-02 | The Two-Tellings Test

B1 | T-06-02

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 1, pp. 14–16

DISTILLED

- A named practitioner's method for sizing up trustworthiness: listen to the person tell the same story twice, note the details carefully the first time, and compare the two versions.
- The degree of consistency between versions is used as the gauge of honesty.
- A person who relates a story differently each time is probably an untrustworthy liar; habitual liars change stories to fit the purpose at hand and forget how they told it before.

- The test is presented as a practical alternative to judging character by impression.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The two-tellings procedure stated as a concrete method with a defined comparison — specifics, not impressions — and the explanation that habitual reconstruction causes the teller to lose track of earlier versions.

VOCABULARY

- *the two-tellings test* — this handbook's name for the procedure; the source does not label it.

T-06-03 | The Third-Party Lie Rule

B1 | T-06-03

Sparkman, *Art of Manipulation* (1978) • locator: Tactic 1, pp. 15–16

DISTILLED

- If you hear a person you trust lie to someone else, cancel the trust.
- The reasoning given is that a person who lies to somebody else will lie to you; there is no basis for expecting them to think more of you later when lying suits their purpose.
- People live by an internal code; if the code permits lying to an enemy it will permit lying to a friend when that gets them something they want.
- Friend and enemy are reclassifiable: a friend who gets in the way becomes an enemy easily, so special status is not durable protection.

-
- Never trust a person who lies to others but says they will not lie to you because you are a friend.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The internal-code model: honesty is governed by category rather than by person, and categories are cheaply reassigned — which is why special exemption offers are worthless.
- The explicit instruction to withdraw trust on observing a lie directed at a third party, rather than to discount it.

T-06-04 | Behaviour Over Declaration

B1 | T-06-04

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 1, pp. 13–16

DISTILLED

- A person who genuinely holds a position does not feel a nervous need to remind you of it; their behaviour in the relationship speaks for itself.
- Words are described as compensation for a lack of substance.
- An example is given of a strongly declared social position adopted by someone whose conduct did not support it, read as an attempt to use the listener.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The over-declaration diagnostic in personal rather than commercial relationships: repeated affirmation of a stance as compensation for absent substance.

B3 | T-06-04

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 9, pp. 69–75; Law 4

DISTILLED

- A triumph gained through argument is Pyrrhic: the resentment outlasts the change of opinion, so agreement produced by demonstration is worth more than agreement produced by words.
- Demonstration is preferred to explication.
- Saying less than necessary is linked to the same principle: the more words, the more common you appear and the less in control, and the more likely you are to say something foolish.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The resentment-cost calculation attached to verbal victory, which is why behavioural demonstration is preferred on effectiveness grounds rather than on stylistic ones.

Gathering Information

T-07-01 | Posing as a Friend

B3 | T-07-01

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 14, pp. 107–114

DISTILLED

-
- Knowing about a rival is described as critical; spies are recommended for gathering information that keeps you a step ahead.
 - Playing the spy yourself is recommended as better than employing one.
 - Polite social encounters are the recommended venue, with indirect questions used to make people reveal weaknesses and intentions.
 - There is no occasion that is not an opportunity for artful spying.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The claim that every social occasion is usable, and the preference for collecting personally rather than through intermediaries, since a spy is an uncontrolled channel.

VOCABULARY

- *artful spying* — information collection conducted inside ordinary social contact.

T-07-02 | The Indirect Question

B1 | T-07-02

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 6, pp. 71–76

DISTILLED

- Discovering a person's real motives and feelings is treated as a technique with specific procedures rather than as intuition.

- The direct question has a place, but only when paired with observation of the immediate involuntary reaction, because the words that follow are managed and the first response is not.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- Pairing the direct question with observation of the involuntary response, on the reasoning that managed words and unmanaged reactions arrive in a fixed order.

B3 | T-07-02

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 14, pp. 107–114

DISTILLED

- Indirect questions are the recommended instrument in social encounters, used to make people reveal weaknesses and intentions.
- Probing is described as a learnable behaviour in polite company rather than as a special skill of interrogators.

T-07-03 | The Three-Second Read

B1 | T-07-03

Sparkman, Art of Manipulation (1978) • locator: Tactic 6, pp. 72–74

DISTILLED

- The key to a person's true thoughts is said to lie in the area around the eyes, where emotions are mirrored clearly.

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- The procedure: look the subject straight in the eyes, ask the direct question, then focus on the immediate expression across the eyes and upper cheekbones.
 - Within three seconds the gut feeling about the question is said to be readable almost always.
 - Used this way the procedure is claimed to defeat attempts to mislead by lying, which is offered as the explanation for why it is nearly impossible to deceive an experienced deceiver.
 - A worked interpersonal example is given: introducing the subject casually, then asking the direct question and reading the immediate reaction rather than the denial that follows.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The three-second window, the specific facial region to observe, and the procedure of pairing a direct question with observation of the immediate reaction rather than of the answer.
- The reflexive claim that experienced deceivers are hard to deceive because they run this read continuously.

Judging Who You Are Dealing With

T-08-01 | Do Not Offend the Wrong Person

B3 | T-08-01

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 19, pp. 137–147

DISTILLED

- There are many kinds of people and you cannot assume everyone reacts to your strategies the same way.

- Some people, once deceived or outmanoeuvred, spend the rest of their lives seeking revenge; they are described as wolves in lambs' clothing.
- The instruction is to choose victims and opponents carefully, and never to offend or deceive the wrong person.
- The law is supported by a long case of a ruler who insulted a rising neighbour repeatedly over a small matter and lost an empire as a result.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The delayed-revenge disposition named as the primary strategic risk, with the consequence that the offence and the cost are separated in time and the offender does not connect them.
- The wolves-in-lambs'-clothing formulation: the dangerous counterpart presents as harmless at the time of the offence.

T-08-02 | The Engagement Decision

B1 | T-08-02

Sparkman, *Art of Manipulation* (1978) • locator: Tactic 5, pp. 59–70; Tactic 10, pp. 117–124

DISTILLED

- Not retaliating is argued on cost grounds: an ego injury creates a persistent enemy and the friction piles problems on you, emotionally and financially.
- A rule of thumb is given for which arguments to contest: let sleeping dogs lie where they do not affect your vital interests.

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- Most arguments are said to be winnable, which makes the decision to have one a decision rather than a necessity.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The vital-interests filter as an explicit criterion for choosing which engagements to enter, with everything outside it conceded by default.

B3 | T-08-02

Greene, 48 Laws of Power (1998) • locator: Law 36, pp. 300–308; Law 20; Law 22

DISTILLED

- Acknowledging a petty problem gives it existence and credibility; the more attention paid to an enemy, the stronger they become.
- A small mistake often becomes worse and more visible when you try to fix it, so leaving things alone is sometimes best.
- Showing contempt for something you cannot have is presented as raising your apparent standing: the less interest revealed, the more superior you seem.
- Not committing to anyone is recommended, with independence described as the position from which others can be played against one another.
- Surrender is treated as a tool where you are weaker: it buys time to recover and to wait for the other party's power to wane, and denies them the satisfaction of a victory.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- Non-response as an active instrument — attention withheld is described as costing the other party more than a reply would.
- Surrender reframed as a chosen timing decision rather than as a defeat.

Framing and Controlled Choice

T-14-01 | The Automatic Response

B4 | T-14-01

Cialdini, Influence (1984) • locator: intro, pp. 1–12; ch. 1, pp. 13–42; epilogue

DISTILLED

- Compliance is frequently produced by a single trigger feature rather than by an assessment of the request; the response pattern is fixed and the cue that releases it is separable from the substance.
- The shortcut is retained because full evaluation is too costly to perform on every ordinary request, so it is correct often enough to be worth keeping.
- Each subsequent principle in the book is one such feature — obligation, consistency, crowd, warmth, credential, rarity — exploited by producing the feature rather than the condition.
- The accelerating case: cues now arrive faster than they can be evaluated, so more decisions are made on the shortcut than before.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The trigger-feature model itself: the claim that a whole compliance routine can be released by one manufactured cue, which is the causal layer under the tactics in B1 and the laws in B3.
- The economic justification for keeping the shortcut, and the resulting asymmetry of the defence.

T-14-02 | The Contrast Principle

B4 | T-14-02

Cialdini, Influence (1984) • locator: ch. 1, pp. 13–42

DISTILLED

- A second item is perceived relative to the first; the same object reads differently depending on what preceded it, in weight, in price and in severity.
- The effect is demonstrated in ordinary selling sequences, where an expensive item shown first makes the intended purchase look moderate without the intended purchase changing.
- The principle operates on the presentation order rather than on the content of either option, so it is available to whichever party controls the sequence.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- Contrast as a framing mechanism distinct from scarcity and from social proof: the value shift comes from the comparison set, not from availability or from consensus.
- The observation that the anchor is usually an option no one intends to sell.

Argument and Demonstration

T-16-01 | Concession and Retreat

B4 | T-16-01

Cialdini, Influence (1984) • locator: ch. 2, pp. 43–86

DISTILLED

- A large request followed by a smaller one produces more compliance with the smaller than the smaller request produces alone.
- The effect is attributed to two mechanisms acting together: the reciprocal obligation created by the other party's apparent concession, and the contrast that makes the second request look moderate against the first.
- The technique also improves how the resulting agreement is felt about afterwards, and raises the rate at which it is actually honoured.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The reciprocal-concession mechanism as distinct from contrast alone, and the observation that both fire on the form of the move rather than on the intent behind it.
- The finding that compliance obtained this way is more durable and more likely to be followed through than compliance obtained by the smaller request directly.

Guilt, Fear and Obligation

T-19-01 | The Uninvited Debt

B4 | T-19-01

Cialdini, Influence (1984) • locator: ch. 2, pp. 43–86

DISTILLED

- The obligation to reciprocate is triggered by the receipt of a benefit, not by agreement to receive it; uninvited favours create a genuine sense of debt.
- The rule is enforced by the social cost of being seen not to reciprocate, which is why opting out is difficult and why the discomfort is about self-image rather than arithmetic.
- The debt can be drawn on for a request wholly unrelated to the original benefit, which separates it from exchange.
- Field settings in which a benefit is delivered so that public refusal is more costly than acceptance.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The absence of consent as the load-bearing feature: the obligation arises from occurrence, not from agreement. Neither B1 nor B3 isolates this.
- The social-marking account of why the rule is hard to refuse, as distinct from a claim about gratitude as sentiment.

T-19-02 | Unequal Exchange

B4 | T-19-02

Cialdini, Influence (1984) • locator: ch. 2, pp. 43–86

DISTILLED

- An obligation set up by a small benefit can be discharged by a substantially larger one; the rule demands reciprocity, not equivalence.
- The uncomfortable state of owing is itself a motive to comply, since agreeing ends it faster than negotiating does.
- The sample, the small gift and the minor courtesy are all described as opening a position from which a much larger request is later made.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The absence of an exchange rate as the mechanism, and the consequent conclusion that the creditor nominates the size of the repayment.
- Discomfort as an independent driver of compliance, separate from the social marking.

Inoculation and Refusal

T-24-01 | Refusing an Unauthorised Debt

B4 | T-24-01

Cialdini, Influence (1984) • locator: ch. 2, pp. 43–86

DISTILLED

- The recommended defence against an imposed obligation is to reclassify the initial act rather than to resist the later request: if the benefit was a device, it is not a favour and creates no debt.
- Reclassification must happen at the point of the offer, since resisting after acceptance means arguing inside the frame.
- Where the benefit cannot be refused, discharging it promptly and in a chosen form removes the balance the technique depends on.

UNIQUE TO THIS SOURCE

- The reclassification move as a defence — declining the premise instead of disputing the amount. B1 advises declining unsolicited largeness but does not give the reasoning that makes the refusal holdable under social pressure.
- The observation that the defence must be decided in advance because it is hard to execute in front of an audience.

Appendix B

State of the Build

This book is written incrementally, one entry at a time. The table below is generated, so it always tells the truth about what is finished and what is still scaffolding.

Published: **33** In draft: **0** Planned: **0** Sources ingested: **4**

The Terrain

- **What Manipulation Actually Is** — •T-01-01 [B1,B3,B4];
 - T-01-02 [B1,B3,B4]; •T-01-03 [B3]; •T-01-04 [B1,B2];
 - T-01-05 [B1,B3]
- **The Practitioner's Equipment** — •T-02-01 [B3]; •T-02-02 [B1,B3]; •T-02-03 [B3]; •T-02-04 [B3]; •T-02-05 [B1]
- **Character Types** — •T-03-01 [B3]; •T-03-02 [B1]
- **Load-Bearing Points** — •T-04-01 [B3]; •T-04-02 [B1,B3,B4];
 - T-04-03 [B3,B1]; •T-04-04 [B1,B3]

Reading

- **Motives Before Words** — •T-05-01 [B1]; •T-05-02 [B1,B3]
- **Tells and Consistency** — •T-06-01 [B1]; •T-06-02 [B1];
•T-06-03 [B1]; •T-06-04 [B1,B3]
- **Gathering Information** — •T-07-01 [B3]; •T-07-02 [B3,B1];
•T-07-03 [B1]
- **Judging Who You Are Dealing With** — •T-08-01 [B3];
•T-08-02 [B1,B3]

Positioning

- **Reputation** — *no entries yet*
- **Attention, Absence and Scarcity** — *no entries yet*
- **Dependence** — *no entries yet*
- **Alliances, Patrons and Courts** — *no entries yet*
- **Concealment and Indirection** — *no entries yet*

Persuasion

- **Framing and Controlled Choice** — •T-14-01 [B4]; •T-14-02 [B4]
- **The Appeals** — *no entries yet*
- **Argument and Demonstration** — •T-16-01 [B4]
- **Delivery** — *no entries yet*
- **Appearance and Compliance** — *no entries yet*

Pressure

- **Guilt, Fear and Obligation** — •T-19-01 [B4]; •T-19-02 [B4]
- **Coercion and the Dirty Way** — *no entries yet*
- **Conflict** — *no entries yet*
- **Working the Hearts** — *no entries yet*

Defence

- **Detection** — *no entries yet*
- **Inoculation and Refusal** — •T-24-01 [B4]
- **Money and Contracts** — *no entries yet*
- **Exit and Aftermath** — *no entries yet*

Cost

- **What You Get Out of Using People** — *no entries yet*
 - **Self-Mastery** — *no entries yet*
- published ◦ draft · planned scaffolding

Colophon

What this repository is. A book whose body is a few hundred small L^AT_EX files, and whose build system is written so that adding a fourth, fifth or fortieth source cannot damage the first three. The reading order is generated from the metadata header of each file, so no index is ever hand-maintained and no file is ever edited merely to make room for another.

The two layers. `topics/` holds the book: one idea per file, fixed slot structure, curated synthesis. `sources/` holds the evidence: one file per source per entry, append-only, never rewritten, with the material found in only one source explicitly flagged. A flagged contribution cannot be dropped from an entry — the build fails if anyone tries. That is the mechanism by which an early source survives a later one being better on the same subject.

Why the files are small. Quality degrades with length, in human and in machine writing alike. Repetition arrives, the voice drifts, and material already written gets paraphrased back at itself. An entry that will not fit in 700 words is two entries, and splitting it is cheaper than repairing the drift afterwards.

The rules. `docs/RULES.md` is the constitution and is versioned. `AGENTS.md` is the short form for automated writers. `tools/validate.py` enforces the machine-checkable subset; `tools/churn_guard.py` enforces the no-wholesale-rewrite rule against git history. Nothing important is left to memory.

State of the build. This edition contains Parts I and II in full and the scaffolding for Parts III to VII. The outstanding work is itemised in the

preceding appendix and in `registry/coverage.md`, both generated, so neither can disagree with the book.

Typesetting. `style/handbook.cls` and `style/entry.sty` hold every visual decision, and load each optional package behind a conditional so that the book compiles on a bare T_EX Live installation. No content file contains a layout command. To change how the book looks, change those two files.